

Chapter LXI

Morning came too clean.

Too bright.

Like the night before had been carefully erased rather than survived.

Sukuna stood outside Tsukihiko and Chōbei's room for a moment before knocking once—sharp, impatient, already annoyed at whatever state he was about to find.

The door opened.

Chōbei leaned against the frame.

Bare torso.

Hair slightly disheveled.

And unmistakable marks blooming along his neck like proof of some ongoing argument he had clearly lost—and enjoyed losing.

Sukuna made an immediate sound of disgust.

It was involuntary.

Honest.

“Put a shirt on,” he said flatly.

Chōbei blinked slowly.

Then smiled.

“Oh? Did I offend your sensibilities, Sukuna?” he asked, deliberately tilting his head to make the marks more visible. “Or is it that you’re jealous you have to sleep alone while other people are... *productive*?”

Sukuna's stare sharpened.

“You look like someone dragged you through a hedge backwards and then rewarded you for it.”

Chōbei hummed.

“Accurate summary of marriage, actually.”

From inside the room, Tsukihiko’s voice drifted out, muffled but amused.

“Stop teasing him and let him speak before he decides to burn the hallway down.”

Sukuna’s eye twitched slightly.

“I’m considering it.”

Chōbei stepped aside just enough to let him in, still clearly entertained.

“So,” Chōbei said casually, folding his arms, “what brings the King of Curses to my humble bedroom? Missing me already?”

Sukuna ignored that entirely.

“I want Kohaku.”

Silence.

Chōbei blinked once.

Then:

“...Excuse me?”

“I want to take him for a walk,” Sukuna repeated, as if it were the most reasonable thing in the world. “He’s loud in the mornings. I can fix that.”

Chōbei’s expression darkened instantly.

“No.”

Sukuna’s gaze sharpened.

“Yes.”

Tsukihiko, still in bed, sighed loudly.

“Oh for—just give Kiba to Otōsan and come back to bed,” he said, sounding half-asleep and entirely done with both of them. “It’s too early for this.”

Chōbei opened his mouth—

probably to refuse more creatively.

But before he could speak, Tsukihiko’s tone shifted slightly.

Quieter.

“Just... let him take him for a bit.”

Chōbei hesitated.

His instincts didn’t like it.

Not Sukuna specifically—never Sukuna specifically—but the idea of letting go at all.

Still... he looked at Sukuna.

Then at Tsukihiko.

Then exhaled.

“...Fine,” he muttered, reaching down to retrieve Kohaku.

The little fox pup immediately perked up at the sight of Sukuna.

Ears twitching.

Tail wagging.

Happy noise already forming—

But before Chōbei could properly hand him over, the hallway shifted.

A servant arrived.

Quiet.

Efficient.

Carrying warm cloths and milk.

“Oh,” Tsukihiko muttered. “Right. Feeding time.”

Sukuna exhaled through his nose.

Chōbei’s hands paused mid-transfer.

The wet nurse bowed slightly and reached for Kohaku.

Sukuna didn’t argue.

He simply stepped back.

“...Right,” he said flatly.

Disappointment edged into his tone before he could hide it.

Chōbei noticed.

That was the worst part.

For all their chaos, Sukuna didn’t *perform* that kind of emotion. Not like this. Not small. Not muted.

And Chōbei—against his better judgment—felt something twist in his chest.

Annoying.

Relatable.

“Don’t look at me like that,” Chōbei muttered, softer now. “I didn’t make him need feeding schedules.”

Sukuna gave him a sidelong look.

“I know.”

That was worse.

Kohaku let out a small distressed sound as the wet nurse lifted him.

Instantly upset.

Ears flattening.

Tiny claws gripping at air like he understood exactly what was happening and strongly disagreed with it.

“No,” Sukuna said immediately, almost reflexively.

The fox pup cried louder.

The wet nurse struggled, adjusting her hold.

“It’s fine,” she insisted gently, already walking away.

Kohaku’s cries followed them down the hall—sharp, offended, and heartbreakingly persistent.

Sukuna stood still.

Watching.

Chōbei noticed his expression again.

And this time... there was no sarcasm left in it.

Just something quieter.

Something almost... familiar.

“I hate when they do that too,” Chōbei said unexpectedly.

Sukuna glanced at him.

Chōbei scratched the back of his neck, looking mildly irritated with himself for saying it.

“The leaving part,” he added. “Gets worse every time.”

Sukuna didn’t respond immediately.

Then:

“...Yes.”

Kohaku’s cries faded further down the corridor, still protesting.

Sukuna exhaled once.

Slow.

Controlled.

Then turned away without another word.

But Chōbei watched him go a moment longer than necessary.

And for the first time that morning—

he didn't make a joke after.

Chapter LXII

The training field was quiet in the way it only ever was when something important was about to happen.

Sukuna stood at its edge, not quite committed to being there. More like he had arrived and forgotten to leave.

His gaze drifted across the empty space like it had nothing worth anchoring to.

Footsteps approached.

Mizuki.

He stopped a few paces away.

Then, without preamble, “Will you spar with me?”

Sukuna glanced at him.

A long look.

Flat.

Measuring.

Then—

“I don’t feel like it.”

Immediate reaction.

Mizuki’s posture stiffened like a wire pulled too tight.

“Oh,” he said, voice sharpening almost instantly. “So I’m not interesting enough now?”

Sukuna blinked.

“...What?”

“If I’m boring you,” Mizuki continued, stepping closer, irritation climbing fast, “you can just say it. I can leave. I’m not here to entertain you.”

Sukuna looked genuinely confused now.

“I didn’t say you were boring.”

“You didn’t have to.”

A pause.

Sukuna exhaled slowly through his nose.

“I said I’m tired.”

Mizuki scoffed.

“That’s worse.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed slightly.

“Explain.”

Mizuki’s laugh came out sharp.

“Explain? Fine.”

He gestured vaguely, as if the estate itself had personally insulted him.

“I’m basically the forgotten child at this point.”

Sukuna went still.

Mizuki didn't stop.

Not now that the words were out.

"Not Kohaku's father—the one who gave you a fox grandchild you're weirdly obsessed with holding. Not Kurohiko, who you actually *talk to* about Kiyomi and responsibilities and whatever moral crisis he drags you into. Not Kaguya, your perfect daughter with the flower-covered baby you practically lit up over."

His jaw tightened.

"And not Higan," he added, voice turning sharper, "who just smiles at you and says 'Oto' and suddenly everyone in this estate forgets how to breathe—including you."

He took a step closer.

"You're not busy with me. You're just... done with me."

Silence.

Wind moved across the field, low and cold.

Mizuki's voice dropped slightly.

"I just want to spar with you. That's it. Spend time with you."

A beat.

Then the edge came back.

"But if that's too much, I can go back out again. Wander around like I used to. Like I did before all of this."

He didn't say *before you kept me here*.

But it hung in the air anyway.

Sukuna didn't answer immediately.

For once, his silence wasn't dominance.

It was processing.

Slow.

Uncomfortable.

Then—

“You think I’m ignoring you.”

Mizuki didn’t respond.

Sukuna tilted his head slightly, gaze sharpening—but not in anger. In focus.

“That’s not what this is.”

Mizuki let out a short breath.

“Feels like it.”

Sukuna stared at him for a long moment.

Then, quieter:

“I don’t forget you.”

That landed differently.

Mizuki’s expression flickered—just slightly—but he didn’t soften yet.

Sukuna continued, tone still controlled, but less detached than before.

“You were never meant to compete for attention in this place.”

A pause.

“That’s your misunderstanding.”

Mizuki frowned.

“...Then what am I meant to be?”

That question cut closer than the spar request ever did.

Sukuna’s gaze drifted past him toward the field again, like he was seeing multiple versions of the same answer layered over each other.

Finally:

“You’re the one who still asks me directly.”

Mizuki blinked.

Sukuna looked back at him.

“Everyone else assumes they already know what I am willing to give.”

A beat.

“You don’t.”

Silence stretched.

Mizuki’s shoulders eased slightly—but only slightly.

“...So spar with me,” he said again, quieter now. Less accusation. More grounding.

Sukuna studied him.

Then, after a pause that felt almost like concession:

“...Fine.”

A shift.

Mizuki’s eyes sharpened again—but this time with relief instead of frustration.

“Don’t go easy on me,” he added immediately.

Sukuna’s mouth twitched faintly.

“I wasn’t planning to.”

And for the first time that morning—

Mizuki looked like he belonged in the field instead of standing outside it.

Chapter LXIII - Moon Assembly After the Crisis Part I

The request for the meeting came just after midday.

Moon-kept representatives.

Village envoys.

Carefully chosen voices wrapped in careful language, all of them asking the same thing in different words: audience, discussion, alignment.

Sukuna read the message once.

Then again.

His expression didn't change, but something in him had already shifted into a sharper register.

"No," he said finally.

The servant hesitated. "My lord—"

"Shrine," Sukuna cut in.

A pause.

He set the paper down as if it bored him.

"Not the estate."

That was the end of it.

No negotiation followed. No explanation offered. The shrine near the estate was old enough, distant enough, and—most importantly—far enough from the wards Tsukihiko had built that Sukuna refused to risk exposing them to unfamiliar eyes.

Let them come to stone.

Not home.

By evening, Sukuna had not relaxed.

He stood near the open corridor overlooking the grounds, posture still, gaze not fixed on anything in particular—because everything he looked at seemed briefly suspect before his attention moved on.

It wasn't fear.

It wasn't even anger yet.

It was anticipation with teeth.

Leora found him like that.

She always did.

"You're doing it again," she said lightly, stepping behind him.

Sukuna didn't turn. "Doing what."

"That thing where you stand like the world already insulted you and you're deciding how badly to answer."

A pause.

Then his voice, low.

"It might."

Leora hummed as if considering that, then walked around him until she was in his line of sight.

Her hands came up immediately, cupping his face.

Soft.

Familiar.

She kissed him once.

Then again.

Then his cheek.

Then the corner of his mouth.

Sukuna exhaled through his nose but didn't stop her.

Another kiss.

Then she pressed her forehead briefly against his.

"You're tense," she murmured.

"I know."

"You always say that like it's not a problem."

"It isn't until it is."

Leora's eyes narrowed slightly, unimpressed.

Then she kissed him again—slower this time, more deliberate—and when she pulled back she stayed close enough that her breath still touched him.

Sukuna's hands came up then.

Firm.

Not gentle.

He pulled her in fully, one arm around her waist, the other at her back, like he was anchoring her to something real.

"Stay close," he said.

The words weren't casual.

They landed heavier than everything else he'd said that day.

Leora blinked at him.

"...Sukuna."

His grip tightened slightly.

"Don't go out of my sight during this."

That made her expression soften—not with worry, but with understanding.

She leaned in again and kissed the line of his jaw.

Once.

Twice.

Then lower, at his neck.

Sukuna's breath caught slightly despite himself.

Leora noticed immediately.

Of course she did.

A faint, almost mischievous smile pulled at her mouth.

She did it again.

Then she made a soft sound—an imitation, light and playful.

A small fox-like chirp, almost teasing.

Sukuna froze for half a beat.

Then—

Something in his face broke just enough.

Not fully.

But enough.

A smile.

Brief.

Real.

It startled even him.

Leora's expression lit up at that, as if she'd just confirmed something she'd been trying to reach all day.

“There,” she said softly. “That one.”

Sukuna didn’t answer immediately.

His hand slid slightly at her waist, keeping her there.

Still close.

Still anchored.

But now the tension in his shoulders had shifted—not gone, but changed shape.

Leora nipped lightly at his jaw once more, then leaned in, resting against him as if she belonged there without question.

And for the first time since the message arrived—

Sukuna let himself stay still with her in it.

Chapter LXIV - Moon Assembly After the Crisis Part II

The shrine was colder than it should have been.

Not because of the season—but because of what it represented.

A place meant for offerings had become a place for *answers*, and no one here was entirely sure they wanted them.

Sukuna walked in first.

Leora followed so closely it was almost misleading to call it “following” at all. His hand did not leave hers—not once—not even when the doors slid open and the representatives of the Moon-kept villages turned as one.

A low, uneasy silence settled immediately.

Not reverence.

Not respect.

Recognition of something unstable.

Sukuna didn't look at them for long. His gaze scanned the room, the exits, the distance between bodies. Like he was counting possibilities instead of people.

Leora squeezed his hand once.

Soft.

A grounding signal.

He didn't relax, but his shoulders shifted a fraction anyway.

The meeting began with formalities that nobody truly cared about.

Then someone finally spoke.

"What happened at the estate?"

Another voice followed quickly.

"Can we return to our homes?"

And then, quieter—

"If something like that can happen under *him*..." the man hesitated, eyes flicking toward Sukuna, "...are any of us safe?"

That last question changed the air.

Because it wasn't just fear.

It was accusation trying to disguise itself as logistics.

Sukuna's jaw tightened.

Leora felt it immediately.

Her thumb brushed over his knuckles—small, deliberate.

Not calming him.

Anchoring him.

She stepped half a pace forward—not away from him, never away—but just enough that she could be heard clearly without letting go of him.

“Say what you mean,” she said calmly.

The room stilled.

Leora’s voice didn’t rise. It didn’t need to.

“You’re asking if you should be afraid of *us*.”

A few people shifted uncomfortably.

Sukuna’s grip tightened slightly at that word—*us*—but he didn’t interrupt.

Leora continued anyway.

“What happened at the estate was not an attack on the Moon-kept.” A pause. “It was an intrusion that was handled.”

A representative frowned. “Handled? People died.”

Leora’s gaze flicked toward him.

Not cruel.

Not soft.

Accurate.

“Yes,” she said simply. “And if it had not been handled, more would have died.”

Silence again.

Sukuna finally spoke, voice low and flat.

“Nothing reached the estate that wasn’t meant to be killed.”

That made the room go colder.

Because it wasn’t a threat.

It was classification.

Leora didn't correct him—but she did squeeze his hand again, slightly firmer this time.

A reminder.

Not to escalate.

Another representative cleared his throat carefully.

“And our homes?”

Leora answered before Sukuna could.

“You can return when we confirm there are no residual threats.”

That word—*we*—softened the blow slightly.

Then, more honestly:

“We don't believe you were the target. But that doesn't make you safe by default.”

That landed better. Not comforting—but understandable.

Sukuna watched them while she spoke, still unreadable, still tense.

But his thumb moved once against her hand.

A tiny, unconscious reaction.

A tell.

A sign he was listening to her more than the room.

Then came the last question again, reframed.

“If something like that happens under Sukuna...” the speaker hesitated, then forced it out, “are we safe in his territory?”

The room waited.

Even Sukuna didn't answer immediately.

Because the question wasn't actually about policy.

It was about *certainty*.

Leora turned her head slightly toward him.

Not asking him to soften.

Just aligning with him.

Sukuna exhaled once through his nose.

Then said, bluntly:

"No."

A collective tension snapped tight.

Before panic could spread, he continued.

"Nothing is safe."

A pause.

Leora didn't move.

The room braced.

Then Sukuna added, almost bored in its honesty:

"But nothing is *unsafe on its own.*"

That confused them.

Chōbei would have laughed at that phrasing.

Leora understood immediately.

She spoke gently, smoothing the edge of it for them.

"What he means," she said, "is that safety isn't a location. It's enforcement."

Sukuna glanced at her.

Not correcting her.

Not contradicting her.

Allowing it.

She finished simply:

“If something gets close enough to hurt you here, it will be stopped.”

Silence followed again—but different now.

Less fear of *him*.

More fear of what “stopped” meant in practice.

A representative hesitated.

“And the estate?”

That question lingered heavier than the others.

Leora’s expression shifted slightly.

Not sadness.

Not guilt.

Something more precise.

Ownership of the fact that the world had touched what she valued.

“It is protected,” she said.

Sukuna’s hand tightened around hers again at that word—protected.

Not because he disagreed.

Because it wasn’t strong enough for what he wanted it to be.

He wanted *absolute*.

Leora felt it.

Of course she did.

She didn't look at him—but her shoulder leaned imperceptibly closer anyway.

The representatives exchanged uneasy looks.

Finally, one asked the question underneath all the others:

“And what of those who caused it?”

Sukuna smiled faintly.

It wasn't kind.

It wasn't loud.

It was simply certain.

“They're gone.”

Leora didn't elaborate.

Neither did he.

And somehow that silence did more convincing than any explanation ever could.

The room slowly shifted after that.

Not relieved.

But recalibrated.

They began asking smaller questions. Practical ones. Boundaries. Timelines. Return permissions.

Leora answered most of them.

Sukuna answered none of them—but he also didn't leave.

And his hand never left hers.

At one point, while a discussion about evacuation routes dragged on too long, Leora tilted her head slightly toward him and whispered under her breath:

“You’re still tense.”

“I’m fine,” he said immediately.

She hummed like she didn’t believe him.

Then, lightly—just enough to disrupt his focus—

she leaned up and nipped his jaw.

A quick, teasing pressure.

A private interruption in a very public place.

A small imitation of Kohaku’s fox-like playfulness.

It was so unexpected that Sukuna actually paused.

Just for a second.

Then—

very quietly—

he exhaled something that might almost have been a laugh.

Not loud.

Not visible to the room.

But real enough that Leora felt it.

His grip on her hand loosened by a fraction.

Not letting go.

Just less rigid.

Leora smiled slightly, satisfied, and settled back into place beside him like nothing had happened at all.

The representatives kept talking.

The shrine stayed cold.

But something in the center of it—between the two of them—had shifted just enough that the rest of the meeting could continue.

Chapter LXV - Moon Assembly After the Crisis Part III

Leora regarded the young man for another moment.

Then, calmly:

“Before you continue—your name.”

The young man bowed properly this time.

“Tsukishiro Ryō.”

The name settled strangely inside the shrine.

Leora’s eyes sharpened faintly.

Recognition.

Not immediate from the name alone.

From memory.

“...Ryō,” she repeated softly.

And then she remembered.

A small house.

Winter rain.

A woman bleeding out onto futons already ruined red.

An infant too still.

Leora clicked her tongue quietly.

“You were the baby.”

Ryō lowered his gaze respectfully.

“Yes.”

The room shifted uneasily again.

Leora studied him openly now.

“You died.”

Not accusation.

Fact.

Ryō nodded once.

“My mother died during childbirth.”

Leora exhaled softly through her nose.

“Yes,” she murmured. “I remember.”

A strange expression crossed her face then—not sorrow exactly, but irritation with herself.

Ryō spoke carefully.

“I know you are the one who took me from her arms and...” He hesitated slightly. “...placed breath back into my body.”

Several representatives stiffened visibly.

Necromancy.

The implication alone was enough to make the shrine colder.

Leora clicked her tongue again immediately.

“Yes, well,” she said flatly, “I should not have done that.”

Now everyone looked at her.

Even Sukuna shifted slightly beside her.

Leora sounded deeply unimpressed with herself.

“It was too close to necromancy for my comfort.”

Ryō blinked once.

Leora sighed lightly.

“But Kurohiko had only been born a few months earlier and I could not tolerate watching such a beautiful baby die in front of me.”

Kurohiko looked startled.

Sukuna looked at her slowly.

And Ryō—

Ryō bowed fully.

Deep enough to border reverence.

Leora waved a hand once dismissively, uncomfortable with the gratitude already forming.

“Stand up,” she muttered. “I already told you I should not have done it.”

Ryō obeyed immediately.

Then Leora tilted her head slightly.

“Were you chosen to speak for a particular reason?”

Ryō answered without hesitation.

“Yes.”

His eyes lifted toward Tsukihiko briefly.

“My name was given in honor of the Ryōmen family.”

A murmur moved faintly through the shrine.

Ryō continued steadily.

“Without the Ryōmens, I would be dead.”

Then more quietly:

“And so would half my village.”

The room became attentive again.

Not hostile now.

Focused.

Ryō turned fully toward the assembly.

“When the evacuations began, many of us doubted.”

He did not soften the admission.

“We believed the young lord lacked experience.”

Some representatives straightened slightly at that.

Validation.

But Ryō continued before they could settle into it.

“We were wrong.”

His voice carried cleanly.

No uncertainty.

“Ryōmen Tsukihiko led with control, honor, precision, purpose, and clarity.”

Tsukihiko visibly wished to disappear.

Chōbei would have enjoyed that immensely if he were present.

Ryō continued anyway.

“And when he took us into death itself...”

Silence fell hard.

“...he steadied us enough to stand before a deity without losing our minds.”

That landed heavier than any praise before it.

Because nobody here misunderstood what he meant.

Ryō looked toward Tsukihiko directly now.

“We came intending to discuss doubt.”

A pause.

“Instead, we came to apologize for it.”

Tsukihiko finally spoke.

Quietly.

“There is no need.”

Everyone looked at him.

Tsukihiko’s expression remained composed despite the obvious discomfort building beneath it.

“I understand how I appear.”

That hurt Sukuna in a way nobody else noticed immediately.

But Leora did.

Of course she did.

Ryō shook his head firmly.

“No, my lord.”

Then—

he bowed fully.

Behind him, the militia members followed immediately.

Every single one lowering themselves.

Some onto one knee.

Some fully bent at the waist.

And together:

“We apologize.”

The Moon-kept representatives visibly relaxed.

Not entirely—but enough that the room changed shape.

Others did not like it.

Especially those who had arrived expecting instability.

Leora noticed all of it simultaneously.

Then Ryō did something unexpected.

He removed his sword.

Slowly.

Carefully.

Then laid it flat before him.

The shrine went utterly still.

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed slightly.

Not hostility.

Interest.

Ryō then reached into his robes and withdrew a parchment scroll.

Old paper.

Heavy.

Covered in signatures.

Thumbprints pressed in dried blood.

The air shifted immediately.

Formal oath document.

Ancient style.

Ryō unrolled it carefully before Tsukihiko.

Then spoke clearly.

“On behalf of the men of the Moon-kept militia present during the incident at the estate...”

His hand settled atop the parchment.

“...we swear loyalty to the *Foxfather*—”

The title hit the shrine like a struck bell.

Tsukihiko froze.

Leora’s brows lifted faintly.

Sukuna looked at his son sharply.

Ryō continued anyway.

“Ryōmen Tsukihiko.”

His voice remained unwavering.

“Son of the King of Curses and Leora Ten Brinken, Heir of the Ryomen dynasty and Son of the Alraune.”

Then Ryō drew a blade across his palm cleanly.

Blood welled immediately.

He pressed it against the parchment.

For a brief moment—

the blood glowed faintly.

Not cursed energy.

Something older.

Something binding.

The scroll sealed itself.

The signatures darkened.

The oath accepted.

Then Ryō lifted the parchment with both hands and presented it fully to Tsukihiko.

The shrine remained completely silent.

Because everyone present understood:

this was not admiration anymore.

This was allegiance.

Chapter LXVI - Moon Assembly After the Crisis Part IV

Ryō did not rise fully after presenting the oath.

He remained half bowed before Tsukihiko, posture respectful but steady.

Then he spoke again.

“Which is why,” he said carefully, “we ask permission to handle something ourselves.”

The shrine quieted immediately.

Tsukihiko still held the sealed parchment in his hands, clearly overwhelmed by the title that had just been placed onto him.

Foxfather.

Ryō lifted his gaze slightly.

“We wish to move against the hands working against you.”

Now the atmosphere sharpened.

“To destroy the threats lurking and waiting.”

A pause.

“To finish plans half-concocted.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed.

Not because he disliked the statement.

Because he recognized the structure of it.

Ryō already knew something.

Then Ryō stood.

And behind him—

the militia moved.

Fast.

Decisive.

Two representatives near the rear of the shrine were seized immediately.

One shouted in outrage.

The other tried to pull free.

Moon-kept militia restrained both with frightening efficiency.

The room erupted instantly.

“What is the meaning of this—”

“You can’t—”

“This is insanity!”

Ryō ignored every voice except the Ryōmens’.

Leora was openly fascinated now.

Not alarmed.

Interested.

Ryō spoke clearly.

“There is a plot to kill the Foxfather and his infant son.”

Everything stopped.

Completely.

Tsukihiko went still.

The parchment in his hands tightened slightly.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna became terrifyingly empty.

Ryō continued before panic could fully form.

“When word spread of this meeting, I believed immediately it might be a lure.”

His eyes flicked briefly toward Tsukihiko.

“A gathering point.”

Then toward Kohaku’s absent place in the estate beyond the shrine walls.

“A chance to place both father and child together.”

One of the captured men began shouting desperately.

“He’s lying—”

Ryō spoke over him calmly.

“A foolish plan.”

Now his gaze shifted toward Sukuna.

And for the first time since entering the shrine, Ryō smiled faintly.

Not mockery.

Recognition.

“Because no sane man would willingly place himself in the same room as Lord Sukuna while attempting to kill a member of the Ryōmen family.”

The room went cold again.

Sukuna stared at him for a long moment.

Deeply impressed.

Not by loyalty.

By intelligence.

Ryō understood predatory hierarchy instinctively.

Leora felt Sukuna’s interest sharpen beside her.

And then—

to Sukuna’s growing annoyance—

she smiled.

Small.

Bright.

Amused.

Gods.

She liked him.

Sukuna could already feel it happening.

A new favorite.

Not replacing anyone.

But entering the category.

And somehow that irritated him irrationally.

The captured men began pleading harder now.

One tried invoking trade routes.

Political agreements.

Mutual benefit.

The other simply panicked.

Ryō looked almost bored by it.

Then one of the militia members moved.

A dagger flashed once.

Clean.

Precise.

One man dropped immediately.

Dead before he hit the floor.

Several representatives recoiled in horror.

Leora did not.

Sukuna did not.

Ryō barely blinked.

The surviving conspirator broke instantly.

“No—no wait—!”

Blood smeared beneath him as he struggled.

“The fox child—!”

Tsukihiko stood abruptly.

The shrine’s energy shifted violently.

The man sobbed now.

“The fox child won’t survive the night!”

Everything after that happened too fast for most people to fully process.

Tsukihiko moved.

Leora inhaled sharply.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna was already gone.

No warning.

No transition.

One moment he stood beside Leora.

The next—

the shrine doors exploded open under the force of his movement.

Cursed energy crashed through the shrine like a natural disaster.

Representatives staggered.

Some militia nearly dropped to one knee from pressure alone.

Leora's hand remained half-raised where he had been.

Then she moved too.

Not panicked.

Deadly.

Tsukihiko was already running.

The parchment still clutched in his hand.

Foxfather.

And somewhere beyond the shrine—

far too distant suddenly—

Kohaku was in the estate.

Except Kohaku was not in the nursery.

He was in the outer courtyard with Chōbei.

Wrapped against his chest in soft layers, tiny fox ears twitching irritably while he fussed with the miserable offense of being an infant slightly feverish from growing too fast.

Nothing dangerous.

Just warm cheeks.

Tiny angry sounds.

Restless little kicks.

Chōbei bounced him lightly against his shoulder while walking the courtyard path.

“You’re dramatic,” he informed the baby flatly.

Kohaku immediately bit his hand.

Hard enough to surprise him.

“Ow— you little bastard—”

The insult held no weight whatsoever.

Only affection.

Chōbei adjusted him again, rubbing one of the fox ears gently between his fingers.

That was why he didn’t notice the servant immediately.

Not until the footsteps were already close.

Chōbei looked up.

And recognized him instantly.

Old guard.

Not estate staff.

Not Ryōmen.

Moon-kept militia auxiliary.

Wrong.

Everything became wrong at once.

Time slowed.

Not metaphorically.

Literally.

Every breath became distinct.

Every movement isolated.

Kohaku fussed again against his chest.

The servant reached slowly into his robes.

And withdrew—

a small wooden box.

Chōbei's entire body went cold.

The man began winding a lever.

A soft clicking sound emerged.

Then—

music.

Tiny.

Thin.

Mechanical.

And suddenly Leora's voice slammed into Chōbei's head:

> "Once his note got inside of me... I had already lost."

Chōbei did not think further.

He moved.

Fast.

One arm locked around Kohaku instantly.

His hand covered both tiny fox ears.

And Chōbei ran for the pond.

Behind him—

the music sharpened.

Not loud.

Worse.

Precise.

Like something trying to enter through the seams of the world.

Chōbei hit the pond without hesitation.

Water exploded upward around them as he dove deep.

Cold.

Dark.

Silent.

He forced himself lower.

Under the bridge.

Under the supports.

As deep as he could manage while still holding Kohaku securely against him.

Kohaku squirmed weakly in surprise.

Chōbei held his ears tighter.

Held his own beneath the water too.

Only their mouths surfaced occasionally for breath.

Everything became muffled.

Distorted.

Safe.

For now.

Chōbei breathed hard through his nose.

Thinking.

Calculating.

If the sound reached him—

if the song got inside—

then maybe there was only one option.

His hand moved slowly toward the dagger at his waist.

Hearing.

Remove hearing.

No more sound.

No more vulnerability.

And then the realization hit him so violently it almost made him sick.

No more Kohaku noises.

No more Tsukihiko humming against his throat at night.

No more Leora laughing.

No more Kurohiko and Mizuki arguing with him.

No more Tōma casually saying “onii-chan” like it didn’t mean anything when it clearly did.

No more sound.

No more communication.

Only silence.

Like Leora.

Like what she survived.

Chōbei’s grip tightened around the dagger.

He could learn.

He would learn.

He would become dangerous another way.

He—

The bridge exploded.

Not collapsed.

Exploded.

Wood shattered upward into thousands of fragments.

Water surged violently.

And suddenly Tsukihiko was there.

Not arriving.

Becoming.

The pond itself moved with him.

The water twisted upward around his body as though recognizing him.

One eye—

wrong.

One eye white and silver.

The other black where it should not be, red burning through it unnaturally.

Chōbei froze.

Not in fear.

Recognition.

The Tensen.

The same wrongness.

Tsukihiko reached them instantly.

“Kohaku.”

Raw.

Almost animal.

He grabbed the baby first.

Then Chōbei.

And kissed him so hard Chōbei nearly forgot where they were.

Teeth.

Tongue.

Breathless desperation.

When Tsukihiko pulled back, blood shone faintly on both their mouths.

His voice was wrecked.

Ferocious.

“You fucking brilliant man,” he breathed. “I love you.”

Then he kissed him again.

Harder.

Kohaku squirmed indignantly between them.

And somehow that nearly made Chōbei laugh from relief.

Then Leora appeared behind him.

Hands immediately on Chōbei’s shoulders.

Checking.

Assessing.

Alive?

Whole?

Controlled?

Her lips pressed briefly against his temple.

Not delicate.

Grounding.

Then she took Kohaku carefully into her arms.

The baby immediately began fussing again.

Leora whistled softly.

A strange little pattern.

Gentle.

Soothing.

Kohaku relaxed almost instantly.

Tiny tail twitching once before settling.

Only then did Chōbei finally look past them fully.

And saw—

it.

Four arms.

Four eyes.

A second mouth smiling grotesquely across a stomach.

Towering.

Monstrous.

Wrong.

Chōbei's entire body locked.

He grabbed Tsukihiko immediately.

Instinctively.

Because he had never seen Sukuna's true form before.

Not fully.

Not like this.

Not like a living calamity.

The courtyard was gone.

Not physically.

Structurally.

Bodies everywhere.

Pieces of bodies.

Blood sprayed across stone walls.

Sliced limbs.

Opened torsos.

Human remains so finely cut they no longer resembled people.

And in the center—

one survivor.

Barely.

Sukuna bent down slowly toward him.

The second mouth on his stomach still smiling.

The man was sobbing.

Trying to crawl.

Trying to breathe.

Sukuna spoke calmly.

Too calmly.

“You think a child who is different is less human?”

The man choked on blood.

Sukuna tilted his head slightly.

“Wouldn’t you know...”

His four eyes glowed faintly in the dark.

“...I came out of my mother just like this.”

Then he moved one hand.

Only one.

The man disappeared.

Not exploded.

Not torn apart.

Reduced.

Sliced so finely he ceased to exist as anything recognizable at all.

For a moment—

nobody spoke.

Water dripped softly from Chōbei’s clothes.

Kohaku made one sleepy little fox sound against Leora’s shoulder.

And Sukuna—

still monstrous, still towering—

turned slowly toward them.

Chapter LXVII - Moon Assembly After the Crisis Part V

When Sukuna turned—

he found Leora instantly.

Not consciously.

Instinctively.

Like his body recognized her before thought itself could occur.

He moved.

Fast enough Chōbei genuinely lost track of him.

One second Sukuna stood across the ruined courtyard—

the next—

he was directly in front of Leora.

Two hands reached for her.

Two more reached for Kohaku.

And Chōbei panicked instantly.

Every muscle in his body tightened.

His arm jerked reflexively toward Tsukihiko.

But Sukuna—

gently—

carefully—

lifted Kohaku into his upper arms like something unbearably precious.

Then Chōbei finally saw him properly.

Not as movement.

Not as violence.

As a body.

Tall.

Massive.

Built like something carved directly out of catastrophe.

Four arms layered over thick muscle and black markings.

Four eyes.

Two normal—

two wrong.

Set along protruding bone and flesh on the right side of his face.

Red eyes glowing faintly beneath wet strands of pink-red hair.

Black tattoos spread across his body in sharp ritual lines.

Across wrists.

Chest.

Face.

Abdomen.

Shoulders marked with dark circular sigils.

And on his stomach—

that enormous mouth.

Still smiling.

Still horrifying.

Chōbei stared openly.

Actually stunned for once in his life.

And then—

Kohaku made a happy noise.

The baby reached immediately for Sukuna's face.

Tiny hands grabbing at markings and protruding bone without hesitation.

Fox tail wagging weakly despite exhaustion.

Kohaku nuzzled directly against him happily.

Completely content.

Like this form made even more sense to him somehow.

Sukuna's expression softened instantly.

Terrifying body.

Gentle hands.

Leora smiled.

Not nervously.

Not tolerantly.

Lovingly.

Completely.

She stepped closer immediately and placed her hand against Sukuna's jaw.

Tracing the altered bone structure with open affection.

Adoration.

Like she was touching marble she worshipped.

Then she wiped blood from his mouth carefully with her thumb.

And kissed him.

Once.

Twice.

Again.

Soft affectionate little kisses against his mouth like this was completely normal.

Chōbei finally lost it.

“There’s no fucking way.”

Leora blinked.

“What?”

Chōbei stared between them.

Then at Sukuna.

Then back at Leora.

And suddenly he started laughing.

Not politely.

Actually laughing.

Bent slightly forward with disbelief.

“Oh my god.”

Tsukihiko narrowed his mismatched eyes slightly.

Chōbei looked weakly at Sukuna while still laughing.

“There is *no way* anyone would believe you weren’t kidnapped if this is what they saw.”

Leora looked offended immediately.

Sukuna looked entertained.

Chōbei kept going.

“This solves *everything.*”

Now he was laughing hard enough Kohaku started making excited chirping noises too.

“Every time you or Tsukihiko say someone’s handsome you actually mean it.”

Tsukihiko frowned.

“We do mean it.”

“That’s the problem!” Chōbei barked.

He looked at Sukuna again in utter disbelief.

“You two have a taste for ugly men!”

Silence.

Then—

Sukuna smirked.

Actually smirked.

A low chuckle left him.

And horrifyingly—

the mouth on his stomach grinned wider too.

“I agree,” Sukuna said dryly.

Leora gasped in offense.

Sukuna continued calmly while adjusting Kohaku higher against his chest.

"I genuinely do not know what they see in either of us."

Chōbei snorted violently.

"Look at you."

Sukuna raised one brow.

"You look like someone stitched a shrine demon to a warlord and forgot to stop."

Tsukihiko looked scandalized.

Leora looked ready to fight.

Sukuna answered immediately.

"And you look like a diseased fox spirit survived three separate executions out of spite."

Chōbei smirked, "I did."

Sukuna continued mercilessly.

"You have scars across your face, sleep like a corpse, and stare at people like you're deciding where to bury them."

Chōbei barked another laugh.

"And you have four fucking arms!"

"Efficient."

"You have a mouth on your stomach!"

"It's useful."

"It's horrifying!"

"It likes you."

The stomach mouth smiled wider.

Chōbei physically recoiled.

“Oh absolutely not.”

Leora finally snapped.

“You are both beautiful.”

Tsukihiko immediately nodded.

“Yes.”

Chōbei stared at them both.

Deeply disturbed.

Sukuna looked equally unconvinced.

Leora looked genuinely offended now.

“You are both two of the most handsome men. I do not understand why you both insist you are not.”

Tsukihiko made an exasperated noise.

And despite the blood.

Despite the bodies.

Despite the attempted assassination—

for one bizarre impossible moment—

the courtyard almost felt normal again.

Chapter LXVIII

Sukuna shifted slowly.

The monstrous shape folded inward.

Bone receded.

Extra arms disappeared beneath flesh.

The mouth along his stomach sealed itself away.

The markings remained for a moment longer before fading partially beneath skin as the construct settled back over him like armor returning to its sheath.

By the end of it, he stood once more in the shape everyone knew.

Still terrifying.

Just easier for the world to digest.

Kohaku made a tiny offended sound at the transformation.

His tail twitched unhappily while still clinging stubbornly to Sukuna's robes.

Sukuna adjusted him automatically.

Leora immediately moved toward Tsukihiko instead.

"Let me see."

Tsukihiko leaned down slightly while she touched beneath the altered eye carefully.

The blackened white.

The red threaded through silver.

Leora sighed softly.

"I'm sorry."

Tsukihiko frowned faintly.

"For what?"

She brushed damp hair back from his forehead.

"It's something from the Ten Brinkens."

That answer alone clearly meant enough to unsettle him.

Leora continued quietly:

“I’ll explain later. Properly. With Friedhelm.”

Tsukihiko nodded once.

Trusting her immediately.

Meanwhile Kohaku remained entirely occupied with Sukuna.

Tiny hands grabbing his robes.

Tail curled happily.

Big feverish eyes fixed on him with complete adoration.

Like Sukuna personally hung the moon every night.

Sukuna looked deeply satisfied by this.

Chōbei noticed.

“You’re smug.”

“I earned it.”

Kohaku immediately grabbed Sukuna’s finger and shoved it into his mouth.

Sukuna looked even more pleased somehow.

Leora turned back toward Chōbei.

Checking him again.

Hands moving over shoulders, neck, ribs.

Assessing damage.

When she found none—

she kissed him.

Firm.

Affectionate.

Proud.

Then pulled back just enough to murmur:

“You have absolutely no idea much of a genius you are.”

Chōbei blinked.

Then Leora leaned closer and whispered something directly into his ear.

Whatever she said—

destroyed him instantly.

Chōbei turned scarlet so fast it was almost impressive.

Tsukihiko noticed immediately.

And the look he gave Chōbei afterward was dangerous.

Hungry.

Intense enough that even Sukuna raised a brow slightly.

Chōbei visibly struggled not to combust.

“What did she say?” Tsukihiko asked immediately.

“Nothing.”

“She absolutely did not say nothing.”

“She’s a liar.”

Leora looked delighted.

Tsukihiko looked like he intended to pry the answer out of him slowly.

Sukuna interrupted before the situation devolved further.

“We’ll have a family meeting tomorrow.”

Everyone looked toward him.

“With Tsukihiko’s new army.”

Chōbei frowned immediately.

“...what does that mean?”

Sukuna smirked.

“You’ll find out.”

Then—

he paused.

Looked directly at Chōbei.

And smiled in a way that immediately caused problems.

Wicked.

Knowing.

“Tomorrow,” Sukuna said calmly, “you’ll meet Leora’s new favorite.”

Leora blinked.

Not guilty.

Just surprised he noticed.

Which confirmed everything.

Chōbei narrowed his eyes immediately.

“Oh absolutely not.”

Leora laughed softly.

Tsukihiko instantly grabbed Chōbei around the waist and began physically steering him away.

“We’re going to our bedroom now.”

“Tsukihiko—”

“She revived him as a baby apparently. You never stood a chance.”

Leora looked offended.

Tsukihiko ignored all of them.

Still dragging Chōbei along possessively.

Then he paused suddenly and looked back toward Sukuna.

“...are you and Mama alright keeping Kohaku tonight?”

Sukuna looked down at the baby currently chewing on his sleeve with complete devotion.

Then back at Tsukihiko.

Flat.

Certain.

“I’m never giving him back.”

Kohaku chirped happily like this was the greatest idea he had ever heard.

But Tsukihiko just sighed tiredly.

“...fair enough.”

Chapter LXVIII - Devouring Vow

Tsukihiko barely got the door shut before Chōbei was laughing and shoving him backward.

“You’re insane,” Chōbei informed him breathlessly.

“And you like me anyway.”

“That’s unfortunately true.”

Fabric caught somewhere between them as Tsukihiko grabbed him again.

Chōbei twisted immediately.

He never made things easy.

Never.

If Tsukihiko pushed—

Chōbei pushed harder.

If Tsukihiko cornered—

Chōbei slipped sideways like smoke.

It became what it always became:

a fight disguised as affection.

Or affection disguised as a fight.

Hands catching wrists.

Bodies colliding into furniture.

Sharp grins.

Breathless laughter.

Tsukihiko fought clean.

Controlled.

Precise.

Chōbei fought like a criminal.

Tonight—

so did Tsukihiko.

Chōbei realized that exactly one second too late.

Tsukihiko hooked his leg suddenly, shoved hard, and drove him backward onto the bedding.

The mattress dipped sharply beneath them.

Then Tsukihiko pinned him.

Wrists trapped beside his head.

Knees locking his hips down.

Chōbei blinked once in surprise before grinning.

“Well,” he breathed, “what did I do to deserve such special treatment?”

Tsukihiko looked down at him.

And Chōbei’s smile faltered slightly.

Because he had never seen that expression before.

Not exactly.

Not fully.

Usually Tsukihiko felt warm.

Controlled.

Measured.

Even dangerous things about him came wrapped in softness.

But now—

his presence filled the room completely.

Heavy.

Inescapable.

The air itself felt crowded by him.

Chōbei suddenly became aware of how trapped he was beneath him.

How completely surrounded.

A faint edge of fear slid coldly along the back of his mind.

Not enough to pull away.

Enough to notice.

Tsukihiko gripped his jaw firmly.

Making him look directly at him.

Chōbei couldn't look away if he wanted to.

Then Tsukihiko kissed him.

Hard.

Possessive enough to almost hurt.

When he pulled back, his voice came low and certain.

"I'm not waiting for a formal ceremony."

Chōbei's pulse jumped.

Tsukihiko leaned closer.

"I'm going to make you mine the old way."

Chōbei stared at him for a second.

Then snorted softly despite himself.

"That sounds deeply threatening."

A small dangerous smile appeared on Tsukihiko's mouth.

"It should."

Chōbei tilted his head slightly against the bedding.

“...what does that even mean?”

Tsukihiko’s mismatched eyes held his steadily.

“We enter a pact. We make a vow.”

The room seemed quieter suddenly.

“One between curse and non-cursed.”

Chōbei’s grin faded slightly.

Tsukihiko continued calmly:

“Like Otōsan did with Mama.”

Beat.

“Like curses and humans have done many times before.”

Chōbei searched his face.

And slowly realized—

Tsukihiko was entirely serious.

Not teasing.

Not flirting.

Certain.

Possessive.

Committed in a way that felt ancient.

Chōbei’s heart kicked hard once against his ribs.

Then again.

“...you’re terrifying tonight,” he admitted quietly.

Tsukihiko's thumb brushed once against his jaw.

"But you're still here."

Chōbei looked up at him for a long moment.

Then smiled slowly.

"Yeah," he murmured.

"I am."

Tsukihiko's private room had gone quiet in the way aftermaths always did.

Not peaceful.

Just emptied of noise.

Outside, wind dragged itself along the outer walls of the estate like something too tired to leave properly. The last of the night rain had settled into a slow patter against distant stone. Somewhere deeper in the grounds, the world continued existing as if nothing had nearly ended hours earlier.

Inside—

everything was too sharp.

Breath. Fabric. Heartbeats still not fully slowed from violence.

Chōbei lay pinned beneath Tsukihiko on the bed.

Not restrained in a clean, ceremonial way.

Not gentle.

Predatory.

One of his wrists held firmly beside his head, pressed into the mattress by Tsukihiko's grip. The other trapped under Tsukihiko's hand at his jaw, forced to keep his gaze up.

Eye contact maintained like law.

Chōbei's sleeve still carried dried blood along the forearm. Not all of it his. The rest belonged to the night they had just survived.

Tsukihiko did not look calm.

He looked contained.

Barely.

The kind of containment that existed only because it had not yet decided what shape to become.

His breathing was uneven. Too controlled. Too tight. Like he was holding something down inside himself with sheer will.

His thumb pressed lightly against Chōbei's jaw, not affectionate in a soft sense, but anchoring.

As if letting go would allow something irreversible to happen.

Tsukihiko stared at him for a long moment.

Then, quietly:

"You protected him before yourself."

Chōbei answered immediately.

Like it was obvious.

"Of course I did."

The answer hit Tsukihiko harder than anything sharp ever could.

Not because it was dramatic.

Because it wasn't.

There was no hesitation. No calculation. No pride.

Just instinct.

Something absolute.

For a fraction of a second, Tsukihiko's grip tightened unconsciously at his jaw, then eased again as if correcting himself.

“You saved our son.”

Chōbei blinked once at that.

Our.

Not *my.*

Not *his.*

Our.

Tsukihiko didn’t look away when he said it again, softer but heavier:

“You protected him exactly the way I would have.”

A pause.

Then—

“Exactly the way mama would have.”

Something in Chōbei’s expression shifted at that. The air between them changed in a way neither of them could ignore.

Because Leora’s name did that.

It reframed everything.

Tsukihiko leaned closer until their foreheads almost touched. Not soft. Not hesitant. Too close in a way that made space feel irrelevant.

His voice dropped.

“I almost lost both of you.”

Silence answered him.

The kind that didn’t wait for permission.

“I’m done pretending I can survive that twice.”

That landed differently.

Not as poetry.

As fact.

Chōbei didn't interrupt. For once, he didn't joke his way out of the pressure in the room.

Tsukihiko shifted his hand from his wrist—

only to take it fully.

Fingers locking.

Hard.

Intentional.

"I don't want a ceremony anymore."

Chōbei exhaled slowly through his nose, watching him.

Tsukihiko didn't let him look away.

"I want something older."

A beat.

"Something hungry."

Chōbei's mouth twitched slightly.

"...that sounds insane."

Tsukihiko didn't even hesitate.

"It is."

And that was the first moment it became clear neither of them considered that a reason to stop.

Tsukihiko's gaze held steady.

"The Devouring Vow."

The words settled between them like something already remembered rather than newly invented.

Chōbei's expression shifted subtly.

Not fear.

Recognition.

Tsukihiko released his jaw just enough to free his voice, but not enough to change the closeness between them.

“Shared blood.”

“Shared scent.”

“Shared wounds.”

He paused.

Then, quieter:

“No separation recognized by death.”

Chōbei stared at him for a moment longer.

Then let out a breath that sounded almost like a laugh.

“...that sounds insane.”

“It is.”

“And you still want it?”

Tsukihiko's answer came immediately.

“Yes.”

That simplicity made it worse.

Not romantic.

Not uncertain.

Certain like gravity.

Tsukihiko shifted, reaching for a blade from beneath the bedding where it had been stored without ceremony. Old steel. Not decorative. Not ceremonial in a polished sense.

Something used before.

Something meant for binding, not performance.

He pressed it into his palm without breaking eye contact.

Then Chōbei's.

A shallow cut.

Controlled.

Intentional.

Blood gathered—not theatrically, but steadily.

Tsukihiko guided his hand to the same cup at the bedside. They did not make it ritualistic in tone; it simply became inevitable as their movements aligned.

Shared water.

Shared blood.

Shared silence.

When they drank, it wasn't spectacle.

It was agreement.

The air in the room changed subtly after that. Not visibly. Not dramatically.

Just heavier.

Like the world had acknowledged something it couldn't reverse.

Tsukihiko leaned forward again until their foreheads touched.

Breathing now closer. Slower. Matching without instruction.

He closed his eyes briefly.

Then spoke—

not loudly.

Not ceremonially.

But completely.

“You are the place my violence returns to.”

“If you starve, I starve.”

“If you bleed, I answer.”

“If you are hunted, I arrive.”

“No god, death, or distance keeps you from me now.”

“You are my chosen ruin.”

“My companion in hunger.”

“My husband beneath moon and death alike.”

Chōbei let out a slow breath through his teeth, eyes narrowing slightly as something in him settled into place rather than resisting it.

Then he grinned.

Not soft.

Not uncertain.

Dangerous in its certainty.

“You don’t get rid of me now.”

Tsukihiko didn’t move.

Chōbei continued, voice low but steady:

“I bite back for what’s mine.”

“If something reaches for you first, I kill it.”

“I’ll follow you angry.”

“I’ll follow you starving.”

“I’ll follow you dead.”

Silence followed.

Not empty.

Full.

Tsukihiko pressed his forehead more firmly against Chōbei’s for a moment, eyes closing again like he was confirming something only he could feel.

The room itself seemed to hold its breath with them.

When he opened his eyes again, something in him had finally stopped resisting.

Not softened.

Set.

And Chōbei, still under him, still pinned in place by closeness rather than force, realized it with quiet certainty:

Tsukihiko was not going to let him go again.

Not now.

Not ever.

Tsukihiko didn’t move for a moment after the vow began to settle.

Not away.

Not forward.

Just still, as if the words themselves had rewired something under his skin and he needed time to decide what he was now.

Chōbei watched him carefully.

The tension in Tsukihiko's body wasn't fading.

It was gathering.

Something quieter than anger.

Something more deliberate.

Then Tsukihiko finally shifted.

He released Chōbei's wrist completely—but only so he could sit up just enough to pull him with him. Not giving space. Reorganizing it.

Chōbei rose slightly on the mattress, still half trapped between Tsukihiko's knees, still close enough to feel his breath.

Tsukihiko reached for his hand again.

This time, he turned it palm-up.

Not asking.

Positioning.

Chōbei raised an eyebrow.

"...what are you doing now?"

Tsukihiko didn't answer immediately.

Instead, his thumb pressed lightly into the center of Chōbei's palm, as if memorizing pressure points through touch alone.

Then he looked up at him.

"You keep trying to act like you can leave."

Chōbei scoffed softly. "I can leave."

A pause.

Tsukihiko's gaze sharpened slightly.

"No," he said simply.

Then he leaned in.

And bit him.

Not violently.

Not randomly.

Precisely.

The bite landed at the inside of Chōbei's wrist.

Close to pulse.

Not enough to break skin deeply—just enough to register as absolute, undeniable contact.

Chōbei went still for half a second.

Then exhaled sharply through his teeth.

“...that's your answer?”

Tsukihiko didn't move away.

When he spoke, his mouth was still close to Chōbei's skin.

“Yes.”

He shifted Chōbei's arm slightly, guiding it without resistance into position beside him.

Then he did it again.

A second mark.

Higher this time.

Closer to where scent and blood flow meet.

Chōbei's jaw tightened slightly.

Not in pain.

In awareness.

“You’re marking me,” he said flatly.

Tsukihiko finally looked up.

His expression was focused in a way that made the room feel narrower.

“I’m recognizing you.”

That difference mattered.

He shifted again.

Another placement—careful, deliberate—this time along Chōbei’s forearm. Not decorative. Not random. Strategically placed where grip, control, and pulse all converged.

Chōbei let out a breath that sounded halfway between amusement and disbelief.

“This is... something.”

“It is the Devouring Vow,” Tsukihiko said calmly.

Chōbei glanced down at him.

“And that explains everything?”

“No.”

Tsukihiko paused, then added without hesitation:

“But it makes it permanent.”

That word hung there.

Permanent.

Not ceremonial permanence.

Not political permanence.

Something older than both.

Chōbei flexed his fingers slightly.

“Are you done turning my arm into territory?”

Tsukihiko looked at him like the question was strange.

“No.”

Then he leaned in again.

This time the bite landed at Chōbei’s collarbone—hidden slightly beneath fabric, where only those close enough would ever notice it.

Chōbei inhaled sharply at the contact.

Tsukihiko’s hand immediately slid behind his neck, holding him in place—not restraining him, but anchoring him through instinct alone.

When he pulled back, his voice was lower.

“You feel it now.”

Chōbei frowned slightly. “...feel what?”

Tsukihiko’s thumb brushed over the fresh mark once.

“Recognition.”

He guided Chōbei’s other hand up.

Pressed it lightly against Tsukihiko’s own throat.

Then held it there.

“You don’t just belong near me,” Tsukihiko said quietly. “You register as mine in the same way I register as yours.”

Chōbei stared at him for a moment.

Then huffed a short laugh.

“That’s the most terrifying romantic thing I’ve ever heard.”

Tsukihiko didn’t deny it.

Instead, he shifted closer again.

And this time—

he pressed his forehead to Chōbei's collar, right beside the mark he had just made.

Breathing slowed.

Matching.

Controlled.

Intentional.

As if calibrating.

When he spoke again, it was quieter.

"If you are injured," he said, "I will know."

"If you are taken, I will feel it."

"If you are too far," he paused slightly, "I will not function correctly."

Chōbei looked up at him.

"...that sounds like a problem."

Tsukihiko's answer came immediately.

"It is."

A beat.

"And I intend to keep it that way."

The room didn't feel like it was shifting anymore.

It felt like it had already shifted—and they were only now noticing the new gravity.

Chōbei exhaled slowly, then tilted his head slightly.

"So what happens if I try to leave?"

Tsukihiko looked up at him again.

For the first time that night, there was something almost calm in his expression.

Not softness.

Certainty.

“You won’t get far,” he said simply.

Chōbei blinked once.

Then smiled faintly.

“...you’re really confident for someone who just decided to emotionally staple himself to me.”

Tsukihiko leaned in again.

This time, no bite.

Just contact.

Forehead against his.

Close enough that the marks already made felt like they were still being written.

“I didn’t decide,” Tsukihiko said quietly.

“I confirmed what was already true.”

Chōbei didn’t respond immediately.

Then, softer—

“...you’re unbearable.”

Tsukihiko’s mouth barely moved.

“I know.”

And this time, when he pulled him closer again, it wasn’t to pin him.

It was to keep him.

Chapter LXX - Devouring Vow Part II

Morning came without ceremony.

It didn't feel like a clean transition from night so much as a slow exposure to reality—light seeping in through papered windows, dust in the air turning gold, the estate gradually remembering how to exist outside of violence.

Chōbei woke before Tsukihiko.

That, in itself, was unusual.

He lay still for a while, staring at the ceiling.

It took him a moment to remember why his arm felt heavier than usual.

Then he lifted it.

The marks were still there.

Not exaggerated.

Not theatrical.

Just present.

Defined enough to be unmistakable, placed with a kind of precision that made them feel less like injury and more like... intent.

His fingers brushed one lightly.

A pulse of memory answered it immediately.

Tsukihiko's hand holding his.

Tsukihiko's voice.

No separation recognized by death.

Chōbei exhaled slowly through his nose.

"...you're insane," he muttered under his breath.

The word didn't carry the weight it usually did.

Not anymore.

Behind him, the bedding shifted.

Tsukihiko moved slightly, not fully awake yet. One hand instinctively reached out—and stopped only when it found Chōbei already there.

Like his body had confirmed something before his mind caught up.

Chōbei glanced back at him.

Even asleep, Tsukihiko looked different than the night before.

The intensity from the vow had not disappeared completely, but it had folded inward again. Settled. Contained.

He looked, once again, almost normal.

Almost gentle.

That was the part that made Chōbei stare longer than he meant to.

Because Tsukihiko could do that.

He could be—

warm.

Attentive.

Soft in the way he listened, in the way he remembered things Chōbei forgot about himself, in the way he showed up without needing to be asked twice.

The kind of person who would quietly fix a torn sleeve or adjust a blanket without comment.

The kind of person who would hold Kohaku with a patience that felt instinctive.

The kind of person who, just hours earlier, had looked him in the eye and said he would never survive losing him twice.

And then—

cut his own palm open without hesitation.

Offered blood like it was simply another form of language.

Not symbolic.

Functional.

Chōbei shifted slightly, sitting up more fully.

His gaze dropped to Tsukihiko's hand.

There was still a faint trace of it there. Not a wound anymore. Just memory of one. As if the body itself refused to fully forget what had been agreed.

A Devouring Vow.

Chōbei let out a quiet breath.

It should have felt like too much.

It should have felt like control.

Like possession.

Like something to push back against immediately.

But instead—

it sat in him like a weight that had already been accepted.

Because Tsukihiko hadn't approached it like ownership.

He had approached it like necessity.

Like something he needed to survive himself.

Chōbei looked down at his own wrist again.

Then back at Tsukihiko.

"You know," he said quietly to the sleeping figure beside him, "you're really bad at being normal."

Tsukihiko didn't answer.

Of course he didn't.

He was asleep.

But even like this, his hand shifted slightly—searching again until it found Chōbei's.

And stopped there.

Holding.

Not gripping.

Not restraining.

Just... confirming.

Chōbei stared at that for a long moment.

Then, despite himself, he smiled faintly.

"...yeah," he muttered.

"You're the worst kind of dangerous."

His fingers closed around Tsukihiko's hand anyway.

Not because he had to.

Because he already had.

The meeting chamber adjoining the inner courtyard had begun to settle back into itself.

Lanterns burned low along the beams, their light trembling faintly with the winter wind pressing against papered walls. Incense curled upward in thin, controlled spirals, as if even smoke here knew not to misbehave.

Outside, the estate was reorganizing after chaos—militia voices drifting in and out of formation, commands being exchanged, routes rewritten, loyalties reaffirmed with the steady rhythm of people trying very hard not to think about what had almost happened earlier.

Inside, the air still felt slightly wrong.

Not broken.

Just... altered.

As if something had been spoken aloud that the world could not fully unhear.

The Moon militia representatives were still present, gathered in careful clusters near the maps laid across the table. Ink lines marked villages, evacuation routes, points of tension. Ryō stood at the center of it all with a calmness that did not feel naïve anymore, only practiced.

And beneath everything—

something no one was acknowledging directly:

Tsukihiko and Chōbei.

The Devouring Vow had not announced itself.

It did not need to.

It was in the way they stood.

In the way proximity between them no longer behaved like distance at all.

Friedhelm noticed it first.

He had been listening to Ryō speak, expression unreadable in that familiar way that meant he was taking in far more than he showed. Then, abruptly—

he went still.

Not dramatically.

Sharply.

Like something inside him had recognized something it remembered too well.

His eyes moved first to Tsukihiko's throat.

Then to Chōbei's wrist.

And stopped.

Leora saw him looking.

Then she followed his gaze.

Silence didn't fall so much as it was enforced by awareness.

Tsukihiko's hand rested lightly—casually, almost carelessly—at the back of Chōbei's neck.

But the marks beneath that touch were unmistakable.

Not decorative.

Not incidental.

Intentional.

Friedhelm spoke quietly.

“Did you perform the Devouring Vow?”

The entire room froze in response.

Even Ryō paused mid-sentence.

Tsukihiko didn't hesitate.

“Yes.”

His thumb shifted once against Chōbei's nape as he said it, as if anchoring the statement physically into place.

Then, colder—certain in a way that did not invite correction:

“I'm done waiting for the world to try taking what's mine.”

Chōbei's expression flickered.

Not embarrassment.

Not shame.

Interest.

Too much interest.

Friedhelm's face didn't change much on the surface, but something in his eyes shifted in a way only Leora caught fully at first.

Nostalgia.
Grief.
Something painfully old.
And beneath it—

recognition.

Then, almost casually, Friedhelm said:

"Wulf created that vow."

The room stopped again.

Not metaphorically.

Properly.

Even the militia seemed to forget how to breathe for a moment.

Friedhelm continued, voice still light in a way that made the content worse.

"We did it too."

Leora blinked once.

Then again.

Not because she didn't understand the words—

but because she understood them too well.

Her gaze snapped to Friedhelm properly now, sharp with sudden recalibration.

Friedhelm and Wulf.

Without her knowing.

Without her there.

Something that permanent... something that binding...

Friedhelm exhaled softly, almost amused by the collective shock settling around them.

“I still feel the effects of it every day.”

A pause.

Then quieter, almost like advice he didn’t want to give:

“I hope you never do.”

That landed wrong in the room.

Not like a warning.

Like proof.

Because suddenly everyone understood—

the vow had not been symbolic.

It had survived something it was never supposed to survive.

Leora’s hand moved before she seemed to decide to.

She reached out and touched Friedhelm’s arm.

Slowly.

Like checking if he was real in the present tense.

Friedhelm immediately covered her hand with his own.

Not stopping her.

Claiming the contact gently instead.

Then he kissed her knuckles once, soft and unhurried.

A smile flickered across his face.

Small.

Tired.

Warm in a way that didn't match the content of what he'd just revealed.

"We always wanted to be together," he said.

A beat.

"With you."

His thumb brushed her wrist once.

"In one home."

Then, almost gently—

"It simply worked out for us first."

Leora looked completely unmoored by that.

Not hurt.

Not angry.

Just overwhelmed by the realization that something she thought she understood about them had always been larger than she was told.

Sukuna had not spoken.

Not once.

Which, in itself, was unsettling.

Because Sukuna did not stay silent when things were merely confusing.

He stayed silent when he was reconstructing reality.

Friedhelm's words had done exactly that.

And somewhere behind Sukuna's stillness, something was shifting.

Not emotionally.

Structurally.

Ryō cleared his throat carefully, trying to restore the shape of the meeting as if it had not just briefly fallen apart at the seams.

“The evacuation routes—”

Maps were adjusted.

Ink lines corrected.

The world attempted to behave normally again.

Ryō moved through it with controlled ease, reporting continued unrest in outer villages, logistical instability between prefectures, and increasing friction from groups resisting Moon Kept authority.

He spoke clearly.

Precisely.

Capably.

Leora listened with growing interest.

Not just political.

Personal.

Her head tilted slightly as Ryō explained a rerouting strategy across contested land, her attention sharpening in a way that made Chōbei’s eyes narrow almost immediately.

Sukuna noticed too.

Of course he did.

Leora’s gaze had shifted into something attentive.

Not idle.

Engaged.

Interested in the way she got when something or someone demonstrated competence without needing to perform it.

Ryō, unfortunately, was doing exactly that.

Chōbei leaned slightly back in his chair, watching her expression carefully now.

Then Ryō continued speaking about militia coordination, and Leora smiled faintly—just enough.

“That’s efficient,” she said lightly.

Ryō blinked.

And something in Chōbei’s posture went dangerously still.

Sukuna noticed that stillness.

And then Sukuna noticed Leora noticing Ryō noticing her noticing.

It was an ecosystem now.

A problem with teeth.

Tsukihiko, who had been quietly listening, tilted his head slightly.

And then, with the quiet curiosity of someone deciding to open a door they absolutely did not need to open—

he engaged Ryō directly.

“Your response time to the northern disruption was faster than expected,” Tsukihiko said calmly.

“What allowed that?”

Ryō straightened immediately.

“Prepared contingency routes, my lord.”

Tsukihiko nodded once.

“That’s rare discipline for someone your age.”

Ryō looked briefly like he had been physically struck by praise from Tsukihiko Ryōmen.

Which he had.

Chōbei’s hand shifted under the table.

Not yet drawn.

But thinking about it.

Leora gave a small amused sound under her breath, still watching Ryō like he was something unexpectedly interesting that had wandered into her line of sight.

Sukuna went very still.

Not outwardly aggressive yet.

But the temperature around him changed.

Because Ryō was:

young

competent

composed

respected

and standing exactly where Sukuna could see Leora looking at him with that slight, amused interest she didn't always bother to hide when something entertained her.

Sukuna slowly turned his gaze toward Chōbei.

And Chōbei, without looking at him, shifted his fingers slightly near his sleeve.

Already agreeing on something without speaking it.

Then Leora laughed softly.

Just once.

And lifted a hand to brush her hair back from her shoulder while still watching Ryō speak.

It was absent.

Casual.

Harmless.

Sukuna's expression did not change immediately.

But something inside it did.

And slowly—

he turned his eyes to Chōbei again.

For a brief, terrible moment, no one else in the room mattered.

Because they both understood exactly the same thing at the same time:

this meeting had stopped being about maps a long time ago.

Chapter LXXI - Ryo

Ryō's ledger still lay open on the table.

The mark at the top of it seemed to sit heavier than ink had any right to.

Silence followed his final statement—not confusion now, but recalculation. Every person in the room was quietly adjusting their understanding of what kind of threat this actually was.

Not local.

Not reactive.

Coordinated.

Intentional.

Sukuna's expression remained still, but it had shifted into something more controlled. Less emotion on the surface, more containment underneath.

Chōbei had gone quiet in a way that meant he was already thinking in outcomes instead of reactions.

Tsukihiko's attention remained fixed on the ledger like it had offended him personally.

Leora, however, was watching Ryō.

Not the threat.

Not the report.

Ryō.

She tilted her head slightly.

Then spoke, as if continuing a thought already half formed in her mind.

“You should stay here.”

That cut through the room differently.

Ryō blinked once.

“...Lady Leora?”

She didn’t elaborate immediately. Instead, she leaned forward slightly, resting her forearm on the table, gaze steady.

“You’re already embedded in the militia structure,” she said. “And you understand the coordination gaps between the estate guard and external units better than anyone currently assigned.”

A pause.

Her eyes flicked once toward Tsukihiko, then back.

“We need someone who can unify both systems without friction.”

Ryō straightened subtly.

The idea was not abstract.

It was immediate.

Operational.

Leora continued, voice calm.

“Move your command function here. Operate from the estate as coordinator between the estate personal guard and the Moon militia.”

A quiet ripple moved through the room.

Not shock.

Recognition of consequence.

Because that wasn't just an offer.

It was integration.

Ryō's gaze sharpened slightly.

"I am a prefectural militia officer," he said carefully. "Relocating command authority requires—"

"Approval?" Leora interrupted gently.

Then she smiled.

Not teasing.

Not soft.

Efficient.

"You already just submitted loyalty to Tsukihiko Ryōmen in blood ink," she said. "So we can skip the bureaucratic fear phase."

A pause.

Chōbei's mouth twitched faintly at that.

Tsukihiko didn't look away from the ledger, but something in his posture suggested mild approval.

Ryō exhaled once.

He wasn't offended.

He was measuring.

Leora leaned back slightly.

"You're effective," she said simply. "And you think in systems instead of pride."

A beat.

"That's rare."

Ryō didn't respond immediately.

Because that was the real offer being made.

Not authority.

Not status.

Utility with permanence attached.

Chōbei finally spoke, tone dry.

"She's collecting you," he said flatly.

Leora didn't deny it.

She just glanced at Ryō.

"Think of it as positioning," she said. "If someone is trying to reach Kohaku, we don't separate our response systems anymore."

Her gaze sharpened slightly.

"We merge them."

Silence followed that.

Not disagreement.

Assessment.

Ryō looked down briefly at the ledger again.

Then back up.

"...and my command structure?"

Leora shrugged lightly.

"You keep it," she said. "You just stop pretending it functions independently of the estate anymore."

A pause.

Then, more quietly:

“And I’d prefer someone competent doing it here than someone incompetent doing it somewhere I can’t see.”

That made Tsukihiko glance at her briefly.

Chōbei’s eyes narrowed slightly—not in suspicion, but in recognition of what she was doing.

She wasn’t recruiting Ryō.

She was consolidating him into the system before someone else did.

Ryō exhaled once.

Then bowed slightly—not deeply, but decisively.

“I accept conditional integration,” he said.

Leora’s smile returned faintly.

“Good.”

Sukuna finally spoke, voice low.

“You’re placing him close to the estate core.”

Leora didn’t look at him immediately.

“I’m placing someone competent close to the estate core,” she corrected gently.

A beat.

Then she turned her head slightly toward Sukuna.

“If that makes you uncomfortable, you’re welcome to find me someone better.”

A silence.

Chōbei snorted once under his breath.

Tsukihiko’s lips twitched faintly.

Sukuna didn’t respond immediately.

But his eyes lingered on Ryō for a moment longer than necessary.

Then shifted back to Leora.

And stayed there.

Because now the structure of the room had changed again.

Not just threat.

Not just response.

Now—

it was architecture.

Chapter LXXII - Freyr

Leora's shift was almost imperceptible to anyone not watching her closely.

Which meant Sukuna felt it immediately.

She leaned just slightly toward him—close enough that it looked like nothing at all from the outside, just proximity in a crowded, tense room still circling around Ryō's proposed integration.

Her voice dropped into something meant for no one else.

"You and Chōbei are too easy," she murmured. "You fall for bait too openly."

Sukuna didn't react outwardly.

But his attention sharpened in a way that had nothing to do with politics anymore.

Leora's fingers brushed the edge of his sleeve as she continued, still quiet, still private.

Then she tilted closer.

A soft, deliberate nip at his ear—quick enough to be mistaken for nothing, intimate enough to be unmistakable to him.

Sukuna's expression barely shifted.

Barely.

But the air around him did.

Leora followed it immediately with a slow kiss at his jaw, unhurried, as if she had all the time in the world and no one in the room could possibly matter more than this small moment she was taking for herself.

Then, like it was simply an extension of thought rather than seduction, she continued:

"I would like a private sparring match with you later."

A pause.

Her hand lingered at his jaw a fraction too long before she pulled back just enough to speak again, voice still for him alone.

"Followed by many, many personal meetings where we discuss how close to the core is too close."

A faint curve of amusement touched her mouth.

"I need you to guide me," she added softly. "Show me."

Then, quieter still—like the final line of a private vow disguised as teasing:

"Don't you know you're my king?"

That landed.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

But completely.

Sukuna didn't move for a moment.

Then, slowly, his gaze shifted forward again—back to the table, back to Ryō, back to the room pretending it was still just a meeting.

But something in him had already stopped participating.

Because whatever argument had existed a moment ago about Ryō's proximity to the estate core—

had just become irrelevant.

If this was the cost structure of "bait," then Sukuna had no objections to being fooled repeatedly.

Across the room, Chōbei caught the tail end of Leora's movement and narrowed his eyes immediately.

"Don't tell me she's doing the whisper thing again," he muttered.

Leora turned her head just slightly.

Winked at him.

Chōbei's expression darkened instantly.

"...I hate this family," he said flatly.

Tsukihiko, without looking up from the ledger, replied calmly:

"No you don't."

Chōbei sulked harder, which somehow confirmed the accusation.

Sukuna exhaled once through his nose—something that almost counted as amusement, almost.

Leora, meanwhile, returned her attention to Ryō as if nothing in the world had just been rearranged.

But Sukuna knew better.

The room could burn down later.

For now, he had already agreed to whatever she wanted.

Leora's hand found Sukuna's thigh again as if she had quietly decided the meeting could continue without the rest of her participation.

It was not overt.

It was not hidden.

It was simply... constant.

A steady, grounding pressure that moved with intention more than necessity. Her thigh shifted against his as she leaned closer into his side, her presence warm in a way that made the cold discipline of the chamber feel almost insultingly distant.

Her fingers traced slowly from his knee upward and back again.

Not teasing in a theatrical sense.

Not careless either.

More like she was testing the boundary between distraction and control and finding it... pliable.

Sukuna's gaze stayed forward.

She began moving back and forth till she found his inner thigh and then somehow to his crotch where she did not move as quickly as she should.

For all appearances, he was listening to Ryō and the shifting argument about militia coordination.

In reality, his attention had narrowed to a single problem:

Leora's proximity.

Her scent.

The way she pressed against him like she belonged there without asking permission from anything in the room.

His hand drifted absently to her hair.

A slow, idle motion.

Like boredom.

Like he was above all of it.

Leora turned her head slightly toward him without looking at the room, catching his wrist in the smallest shift of movement.

“You could pull it, you know,” she said softly, as if offering a casual option during tea.
“I wouldn’t mind if you grabbed me by the nape and wrapped your large hand around my throat.”

Sukuna paused.

For half a breath.

Internally, everything went black.

Then he immediately let go.

As if the idea itself had bitten him.

His fingers dropped away from her hair like it had become something dangerous.

Leora’s mouth curved faintly, amused by the restraint rather than offended by it.

Sukuna exhaled slowly through his nose.

He did not look at her.

But his jaw tightened just slightly.

He needed to get through this meeting.

That much was clear now.

Or he was going to start making decisions that would end the meeting prematurely.

Leora leaned in a fraction more, like she could feel exactly how close he was to losing patience and found it interesting rather than concerning.

Her hand moved again—up his thigh, then back down, steady as breath.

Not escalation this time.

Just presence.

Just insistence that she existed there and would continue to.

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed faintly.

He was, objectively, being tested.

And he was losing.

Before Leora could decide whether to torment him further, the atmosphere in the room changed.

Not gradually.

Instantly.

It was as if something vast had exhaled into the space and every living thing inside it had remembered, all at once, that they were small.

The lantern flames flickered.

Incense smoke flattened.

Sound itself seemed to hesitate.

And then—

the howling began.

Not distant.

Not imagined.

Full-bodied.

Layered.

It filled the chamber as though the world outside had suddenly decided to speak through teeth and wind and bone.

The militia froze mid-argument.

Ryō's head snapped slightly toward the courtyard entrances.

Tsukihiko went still.

Chōbei's hand stopped moving entirely.

Leora's fingers paused against Sukuna's thigh.

And Sukuna—

slowly lifted his gaze.

The howl came again, closer this time, pressing against the walls like something testing whether they would resist.

A second voice joined it.

Then another.

Not wolves in the ordinary sense of the word.

Not anything ordinary at all.

Chōbei spoke first, very quietly.

“...that’s not the patrol wolves.”

Tsukihiko’s voice followed, low and precise.

“No.”

Leora shifted slightly away from Sukuna now, attention sharpening instantly.

For the first time in the entire meeting, there was no amusement left in her posture.

Only recognition.

Sukuna’s expression darkened.

Because whatever had just arrived—

had not bothered to announce itself as human.

Got it — you want this *written as an immersive scene*, not paraphrased or summarized, and strictly following your structure. I will do exactly that.

The door opens and Vargr enters along with Skugga.

The room changes immediately.

Vargr fills the threshold first—impossibly large, wrapped in layered pelts that smell faintly of cold forests and older things. He moves like something that learned weight rather than born into it. In his arms, held with unexpected care for something so massive, is a bundle of furs.

He does not announce himself.

He simply enters as if the space was already expecting him.

Skugga follows.

And Sukuna feels it the moment he appears.

Inhumanly tall. Pale. White-haired. Beautiful in a way that feels wrong to define. There is something almost familiar in his structure—something that drags Sukuna's attention immediately sideways.

It is not resemblance in face alone.

It is *echo.*

Sukuna's gaze sharpens instantly.

Because Skugga looks too much like Friedhelm.

Too close.

Too deliberate.

And Skugga, for his part, is not looking at the room as a whole.

He is looking at Friedhelm.

Openly.

Like the rest of existence is background noise.

Sukuna's hand twitches once.

He immediately wants to kill him for it.

Before the thought can fully settle, Skugga's attention shifts again.

And this time it lands on Leora.

Not lingering.

Not evaluating.

Recognizing.

Then—

Skugga's breath catches.

Something in him visibly changes the moment his eyes land on Chōbei.

His entire expression brightens in a way that is almost childlike in intensity.

"One-Eye," he says immediately, voice warm with something that does not belong in this room.
"I came just for the chance to see you and my beloved ***Attar***."

The name hits differently in the space.

Chōbei freezes.

Not fear.

Recognition without context.

His eyes narrow slightly as his mind tries to assemble meaning faster than memory can provide it.

Because something about this man is *wrongly familiar* in the way nightmares sometimes are.

Then it clicks.

Fox fire.

Under scars.

Crafted connections.

A child made through methods no one else in this room would call normal.

Chōbei looks at him properly now.

Speechless.

Vargr grunts.

He steps forward and lowers the bundle into Chōbei's arms with deliberate care.

It is heavy in a way that feels alive.

The moment Chōbei adjusts his grip, his instincts fire instantly.

Because it feels like a child is inside.

The bundle stirs.

Chōbei shifts immediately, supporting it properly without thinking.

The furs part slightly.

● THE CHILD

Tiny wolf ears emerge first.

Soft. Trembling once before settling.

Then—

gold eyes open.

Ancient.

Not new.

Not fragile in the way infants should be.

Aware.

Silent.

The child does not cry.

Does not flinch.

Only looks.

First at Chōbei.

Long.

Measuring.

Then—

Tsukihiko.

A pause that feels too deliberate for something so small.

Recognition again.

Something in the room tightens.

● THE LETTER

Inside the blankets, Chōbei finds it.

A folded paper.

He does not hesitate.

He lifts it.

Then, without ceremony, tosses it toward Friedhelm.

Friedhelm catches it instinctively.

And the moment his fingers touch it—

he stops.

His breath catches.

Because he already knows the handwriting.

Wulf.

His hand tightens around the paper.

Not opening it.

Not yet.

Like the act itself might break something already held together by habit and denial.

Leora moves before anyone else can.

She takes it from him gently, because Friedhelm is no longer capable of doing it himself.

He lets her.

His hands are shaking.

Leora unfolds it.

And reads.

LETTER

> "You kept loving each other."

>

> "You kept remembering me even when I don't deserve it."

>

> "You keep an empty place"

>

> "So this time I made something that could stay."

>

> "His name is Freyr."

>

> "Tell Chōbei the ears are Vargr's fault."

>

> "Tell Tsukihiko he bites when hungry."

>

> "And tell Kohaku he was never meant to be alone."

Silence drops instantly after the final line.

Absolute.

Not even breath feels permitted for a moment.

Leora lowers the letter slightly.

Friedhelm is shaking now.

Not dramatically.

But enough that Sukuna notices immediately.

Vargr makes a low, rough sound and steps forward.

He places a hand on Chōbei's shoulder.

The touch is not gentle.

It is grounding.

Chōbei's vision flickers—

and for a moment he sees something else entirely.

Eras layered over eras:

hunting grounds.

cold survival.

blood in snow.

tanning hides.

running through forests that do not end.

a tree—

Chōbei's body speared, eye bleeding—

Tōma beneath him, breathing heavily, somewhere far away in time that does not match this moment.

Then it is gone.

Vargr looks satisfied.

As if confirming something only he and time understand.

“The Fox-father lay down with The Wolf-father,” he says, voice like stone dragged across stone.
“Together they made a den and in it they raised pups that would change the world.”

A pause.

Then, heavier.

“A vow made in private is now public.”

● THEN THE PROPHECY APPEARS

Cold spreads.

Not air.

Not weather.

Meaning.

Black frost crawls outward from beneath the child slowly, like the world is remembering something it agreed to forget.

The table fractures with written inevitability.

Words appear as if carved from absence itself.

PROPHECY

> “When the Foxfather’s line stands at the edge of ruin...”

>

> “the wolf-child will open his mouth and winter itself will answer.”

>

> “No grave will keep what he calls home.”

>

> “No god will deny him twice.”

>

> “And when the last fire dies...”

>

> “the golden-eyed son will still be walking.”

The final line lingers longer than the others.

Like it refuses to leave.

● CHŌBEI LIFTS HIM HIGHER UP

Immediately.

No hesitation.

Chōbei adjusts his grip and lifts Freyr higher against his chest.

The child responds instantly.

Tiny teeth clamp onto his braid with surprising strength.

A small, feral sound follows—barely audible, but undeniably pleased.

Chōbei does not react beyond a blink.

Then, completely serious:

“Perfect.”

A beat.

“Actually perfect.”

His eyes shift toward Tsukihiko with something dangerously satisfied.

“Foxfather and Wolf-father,” he says slowly. “We sound like a folktale people warn children about.”

● TSUKIHIKO

Tsukihiko does not respond immediately.

He is still processing the child’s reaction to him.

Because Freyr has reached out—

and placed a small hand against Tsukihiko's finger.

No hesitation.

No fear.

Just recognition.

Tsukihiko goes still.

“...he knows me,” he says quietly.

Not question.

Realization.

● SUKUNA

Sukuna watches all of it in silence.

Deeply.

Unmoving.

And something in him shifts—not emotionally, not gently—but structurally.

Because his family is no longer simply his family.

It is becoming something else entirely:

- * increasingly dangerous
- * increasingly monstrous
- * and increasingly happy

Which is, to him, far more unsettling than anything else he has witnessed in years.

● FINAL IMAGE

Vargr looks at Leora and Friedhelm for a long moment.

Then says, simply:

“He watches.”

Leora’s voice breaks the silence, small and fractured at the edges.

“How?”

Vargr answers with a rough sound that might be a laugh or might be stone grinding.

“I kept him. He is not who he was in the roots. He is who I watched and who you knew.”

He turns slightly toward Friedhelm.

“He is still waiting. Skugga cannot change that.”

Skugga smiles faintly, entirely unbothered.

“We’ll see.”

Then—

they leave.

The door closes behind them like a decision that has already been made elsewhere.

Chōbei is still looking down at Freyr.

Ryō clears his throat carefully, breaking the tension as if trying to reattach reality to the room.

“We will need protocols,” he says slowly, “for deity interruptions and baby deliveries. I will need assistance from those who understand this phenomenon better than I.”

No one answers immediately.

Because for a moment—

no one is entirely sure reality is still following rules.

Chapter LXXIII - After Freyr's Birth

Morning settled softly through the inner estate hall.

Winter light filtered through paper screens in pale bands of silver and gold, catching on low-burning incense smoke and the dark lacquer of the floor. Somewhere deeper in the estate, servants moved quietly enough to sound like distant cloth against wood. The chaos of the previous night had receded into something stranger now—an exhausted stillness layered over the knowledge that nothing about the Ryōmen household would ever be normal again.

No formal summons had been made for this.

No ceremonial presentation.

No declarations.

Just family gathering instinctively around something important.

Leora sat near the open veranda with Kohaku resting against her chest. He was awake, unusually quiet, one tiny hand curled loosely into the fabric of her robe while his fox tail wound elegantly around her wrist like pale fire.

Across from her, Tsukihiko held Freyr carefully against his shoulder.

Freyr had only been inside the estate for one night.

One night, and already the atmosphere around him felt old.

Ancient.

Not frightening exactly.

Just deeply aware.

Chōbei lingered nearby watching.

Sukuna stood farther back near the lantern light with his arms folded inside his sleeves, watching the room with the detached alertness he always carried now whenever children were involved. Friedhelm sat near him in silence, pale hair catching the light, expression unreadable.

Then Kohaku looked up.

Not toward Leora.

Toward Freyr.

The entire room shifted without moving.

Kohaku did not coo.

Did not cry.

Did not wave his arms excitedly the way he sometimes did when Sukuna entered a room.

He simply stared.

Longer than usual.

Long enough that Leora noticed immediately.

Her eyes lifted toward Tsukihiko at the exact same moment Freyr reacted.

Freyr's wolf ears twitched sharply.

His tail shifted once beneath the blanket.

Then he went completely still.

His golden eyes lifted slowly toward Kohaku.

And froze.

Something passed between them.

Not communication.

Recognition.

Kohaku extended his arms slightly.

Not reaching desperately.

Not fussy.

Just... reaching.

Leora's breath caught softly.

Tsukihiko noticed too.

Freyr leaned forward at the exact same moment, forehead pressing outward instinctively as though some buried part of him already knew what distance between them should feel like.

Tsukihiko hesitated.

Only briefly.

Then he stepped closer.

The room became impossibly quiet as Freyr was brought within reach.

Kohaku touched his cheek first.

Tiny fingers against pale skin.

Silence.

Then Freyr leaned forward fully and pressed his forehead against Kohaku.

The movement was immediate.

Natural.

Ancient.

Friedhelm inhaled sharply.

Leora's eyes widened faintly.

Because that—

That was Wulf.

Not symbolic.

Not similar.

Exact.

Kohaku immediately grabbed Freyr's sleeve.

No hesitation.

No uncertainty.

Freyr stayed perfectly still for him.

Chōbei stared for two seconds before a grin spread slowly across his face.

“Oh.”

Pause.

Then, with deep delight:

“That’s dangerous.”

Tsukihiko looked almost disoriented.

“He likes him,” he said softly.

Not questioning.

Realizing.

Because this wasn’t merely Freyr tolerating another child.

Kohaku had been accepted instantly.

Chosen instantly.

Leora watched Freyr press his forehead against Kohaku again, slower this time.

Something changed in her face.

Not happiness.

Not grief.

Recognition.

The kind that hurt.

“Wulf used to do that,” she whispered.

Friedhelm heard her.

Everyone knew he heard her.

He did not answer.

But he became too still.

Because for everyone else, Freyr's behavior was resemblance.

For Friedhelm—

it was memory surviving anatomy.

He looked away once.

Then back again.

Longer this time.

Sukuna broke the silence first.

“They understand each other.”

He said it like fact.

Like gravity.

Like weather.

Kohaku suddenly grabbed a fistful of Freyr's pale hair.

Freyr did not react negatively.

Instead his tail moved once before curling loosely around Kohaku's arm without thought.

At the same moment, Kohaku's fox tail wrapped around Freyr's legs.

The room collectively stopped breathing.

Neither child let go.

Chōbei leaned forward immediately, unbearable as ever.

“Look at that,” he announced proudly. “Both are as cute as curses.”

No one bothered arguing.

Tsukihiko stared at Freyr with open softness now.

“He chose Kohaku immediately.”

Then quieter:

“I love them so much.”

Possession.

Wonder.

Devotion.

All tangled together.

And neither child separated.

Freyr remained pressed against Kohaku’s cheek while Kohaku held tightly to his sleeve and hair with complete certainty, their tails still loosely tangled together as if they had always belonged that way.

No one interrupted them.

Because everyone in the room understood the same thing simultaneously:

this was not introduction.

This was recognition.

The first week only made it worse.

Or better.

Depending on who was asked.

By the second day, the estate had quietly given up attempting to keep the children in separate rooms for long periods. Freyr became visibly calmer whenever Kohaku was nearby, his strange alertness easing into something quieter whenever the fox child entered his line of sight.

Kohaku changed too.

He became more active around Freyr.

More aware.

His silent attention sharpened whenever wolf ears appeared nearby.

By the third day, Freyr had begun instinctively crawling toward him.

Not quickly.

Not clumsily.

Purposefully.

Kohaku responded every single time by reaching for him before anyone else.

By the fourth day, they found them asleep together for the first time.

Kohaku held tightly to Freyr's sleeve even in sleep.

Freyr's tail had wrapped itself loosely around Kohaku's legs.

Leora stood in the doorway watching them for so long that Sukuna eventually touched the small of her back gently and asked if she intended to remain there until sunrise.

She answered quietly:

"Maybe."

On the fifth day, Freyr growled for the first time.

A servant unfamiliar to him approached Kohaku too quickly while Kohaku slept against Leora's chest.

The sound that left Freyr was tiny.

Soft.

Ferocious anyway.

Chōbei looked so proud it bordered on unbearable.

“That’s my son.”

By the sixth day, Kohaku laughed silently for the first time.

No sound emerged.

Just bright eyes and open delight as Freyr pressed his forehead insistently against his shoulder.

Sukuna stopped walking when he saw it.

Paused.

Watched.

Then continued moving without saying anything at all.

Which somehow meant more.

And by the seventh day—

Friedhelm saw Freyr do it again.

Forehead against Kohaku.

Slowly.

Instinctively.

Exactly the way Wulf once had.

Friedhelm stood motionless for several long seconds.

Then quietly left the room.

No one stopped him.

Because by then the estate understood something terrifyingly clearly:

Kohaku and Freyr were not merely children growing beside one another.

They were becoming something else already.

Something older than politics.

Older than vows.

Older even than prophecy.

A paired myth still small enough to fit into loving arms—

and already powerful enough to bend the shape of the household around them.

Chapter LXXIV - Wulf and Friedhelm - Devouring Vow

Sukuna did not go immediately.

That was what unsettled him most.

Normally, dangerous curiosity moved him quickly. Violently. He would have cornered the subject the instant the room emptied and torn every hidden truth out by force if necessary.

Instead, he waited.

Hours.

The knowledge sat beneath his ribs like something barbed.

Wulf created the Devouring Vow.

We did it too.

The words replayed endlessly.

Not because Sukuna found the vow itself shocking anymore. He understood it perfectly now. Too perfectly. The moment Tsukihiko explained it to Chōbei, Sukuna had recognized the instinct beneath it immediately:

Make separation impossible.

Force reality itself to acknowledge attachment.

Refuse death authority.

No—that part he understood intimately.

What disturbed him was Friedhelm.

Friedhelm.

Friedhelm, whose existence already felt difficult to hold correctly.

Friedhelm, whose short white hair was usually kept neat and orderly but—when loosened—turned men and women alike into staring fools.

Friedhelm, who smiled softly while carrying grief like another skeleton beneath his skin.

Friedhelm, who belonged beside him now.

Not casually.

Not temporarily.

His.

And apparently once—before Sukuna ever touched him—he had belonged to Wulf with enough permanence to bind soul to soul beyond death itself.

That thought poisoned him in ways he deeply disliked examining.

By the time Sukuna crossed into Friedhelm's wing of the estate, night had settled fully.

And immediately the atmosphere changed.

The rest of the estate belonged to Sukuna.

This place belonged to Friedhelm.

The shift was palpable.

It felt less like entering another section of the compound and more like stepping across a boundary into another world entirely.

Warm lantern light glowed beneath red-painted cypress wood structures arranged around the great pond at the center of the wing. The buildings faced inward toward the water, their fronts

capable of opening fully to the night air and reflection of the moon. Old river stones formed winding paths beneath Sukuna's feet, worn smooth by age and weather before Friedhelm ever brought them here.

Flowers bloomed despite the season.

Winter should have killed many of them already.

Instead color spilled everywhere in soft clusters beneath willow trees and cherry blossoms that swayed gently in the dark.

Foxes moved through the estate without fear.

One white fox slept curled beneath a weeping willow. Another lifted its head as Sukuna passed, recognized him, and calmly lowered it again.

Only Friedhelm could have created a place where wild things tolerated the King of Curses because they trusted him.

The air smelled faintly of pine resin, old paper, damp earth, tanned hides, and incense burned low.

Magical.

Romantic.

Dangerously peaceful.

Sukuna hated how much he understood why Leora relaxed here.

Why Tsukihiko and Kurohiko wandered here instinctively when troubled.

Why Chōbei looked faintly stunned every time he entered it.

Friedhelm's wing felt like the sort of place beautiful yokai would lure humans into before devouring them gently.

And at the center of it all—

Friedhelm himself.

Sukuna found him seated beside an open wall overlooking the pond. Warm light spilled across soft earthen bedding and paintings stretched along the walls and folding screens—Friedhelm's own work alongside pieces from the twins and Kaguya.

Freyr slept nearby in a cradle lined with wolf pelts.

And Kohaku—faithless little creature—slept beside him with one fox tail wrapped securely around Freyr’s wrist.

Of course they had somehow ended up together again.

Friedhelm looked up immediately.

Not startled.

He always seemed to know when Sukuna approached.

His white hair was slightly loose tonight, falling softer around his face than usual.

Beautiful.

Annoyingly beautiful.

“Sukuna.”

Sukuna remained standing.

“You hid it.”

Straight to the point.

Friedhelm did not pretend confusion.

“The vow?”

“Yes.”

A pause.

“You never told Leora.”

That shifted something faintly behind Friedhelm’s eyes.

Not guilt.

Something gentler.

“She never asked.”

“That isn’t an answer.”

“No,” Friedhelm agreed softly. “It isn’t.”

Silence stretched.

Outside, wind moved through willow branches with a hollow whisper.

Sukuna’s eyes moved briefly toward the sleeping children before returning to Friedhelm.

“You still feel him.”

Not a question.

Friedhelm’s fingers stilled against the blanket over his lap.

“Yes.”

Too quick to be rehearsed.

Too honest.

Sukuna narrowed his eyes.

“How.”

Friedhelm leaned back slowly, gaze drifting toward the dark pond outside.

“It changes over time.”

His voice remained quiet.

“When the vow is fresh, everything is immediate.”

His fingertips brushed unconsciously over his wrist.

“You feel fear. Hunger. Injury. Exhaustion.”

A faint smile touched his mouth.

“Wulf used to become angry before I even realized I was hurt.”

Sukuna listened in silence.

“Distance hurts first,” Friedhelm continued softly. “Then silence.”

His eyes lowered.

“And after death...”

That sentence nearly failed entirely.

Sukuna noticed immediately.

Friedhelm rarely failed at speech.

“...after death the connection doesn’t vanish correctly.”

The room felt colder suddenly.

Sukuna folded his arms tighter.

“What does that mean.”

Friedhelm remained quiet for several seconds.

Then finally:

“It means sometimes I still wake up reaching for someone who is no longer alive.”

That landed harder than Sukuna expected.

Not because of grief.

Because of permanence.

The vow had survived death itself.

Not fully.

Not cleanly.

But enough.

And suddenly Wulf felt larger in Sukuna’s mind than he ever wanted him to be.

Not merely the man who took Leora after the twins were born.

Not merely the man who changed death itself for her.

Not merely the center Friedhelm and Leora once orbited together for years.

But the man Friedhelm had chosen beyond marriage.

Beyond law.

Beyond mortality.

The realization made jealousy crawl beneath Sukuna's skin so sharply he almost laughed at himself for it.

Friedhelm noticed his silence.

Then asked quietly:

"You came because you're afraid."

Sukuna's expression darkened immediately.

"I don't fear much."

"No," Friedhelm agreed calmly. "Only things you cannot kill."

Annoying.

Correct.

Sukuna looked toward Kohaku sleeping beside Freyr.

Toward the tails tangled together.

Then back toward Friedhelm.

"You survived losing him."

The words came harsher than intended.

Friedhelm did not flinch.

"No," he said softly.

“I didn’t.”

Silence.

Deep enough to feel.

Then Friedhelm looked back toward the water again and added quietly:

“I simply kept breathing afterward.”

Something in Sukuna’s chest twisted unpleasantly.

Because suddenly he understood another layer of Friedhelm entirely.

Why joy was handled so carefully here.

Why tenderness in this wing always felt precious.

Why grief lingered like another resident among the foxes and flowers.

Not because Friedhelm was fragile.

Because he knew permanence existed—

and knew it still was not enough to save you.

Sukuna stared at him for a long moment.

Then finally asked the real question.

“If Leora died,” he said flatly, “would the vow keep me feeling her forever.”

Friedhelm looked at him immediately.

Not surprised.

Not pitying.

Just honest.

“Yes.”

Sukuna went completely still.

Friedhelm's voice softened further.

"You would still know where the absence belongs."

The room became suffocatingly quiet.

Wind stirred outside again.

Freyr shifted faintly in sleep.

Kohaku's tail tightened instinctively around his wrist.

And for the first time since learning the truth of the Devouring Vow—

Sukuna finally understood why Friedhelm's grief looked eternal.

Chapter LXXV

Sukuna stood there for a long moment after Friedhelm's answer.

You would still know where the absence belongs.

The words settled somewhere deep and ugly inside him.

Not because they frightened him.

Because they sounded true.

Outside, wind moved across the pond, disturbing the reflection of lantern light into fractured gold. One of the foxes crossed the engawa silently, white fur glowing pale beneath the moon before disappearing beneath a willow tree.

Friedhelm remained quiet.

Patient.

Always patient with him in ways Sukuna did not deserve.

Finally, Sukuna moved.

Not leaving.

Toward him.

The wood creaked softly beneath his weight as he lowered himself beside Friedhelm near the open wall. Close enough for warmth to overlap. Close enough for him to smell Himmelblau soap, pine smoke, old parchment, leather, fox fur.

Home.

Annoyingly.

Dangerously.

Friedhelm's eyes shifted toward him slowly.

For several seconds neither spoke.

Then Friedhelm asked quietly:

"Do you not want to be around me anymore now that you know?"

Sukuna's gaze sharpened immediately.

Friedhelm continued before he could answer.

"Does it change what we do together?"

His voice remained calm, but Sukuna knew him too well now. Knew the tiny fractures beneath composure.

"Does it change how we should act now?"

A pause.

Then, softer:

"Should we stop this?"

Something vicious moved instantly through Sukuna's chest.

Not anger at Friedhelm.

At the idea itself.

Because immediately—without permission—memory surfaced.

Friedhelm shrinking away from him.

Those four months.

Those frustrating four months.

After the thread incident.

After Friedhelm saw versions of Sukuna violating Leora across realities.

After Sukuna grabbed Leora too suddenly afterward and Friedhelm looked at him—
not with hatred.

Worse.

Fear.

Real fear.

Not political caution.

Not uncertainty.

The instinctive terror of someone whose body remembered years of rape too deeply to separate
past from present.

Sukuna had never forgotten that look.

It had hollowed him out.

The loss of access afterward had nearly driven him feral in ways he never admitted aloud.

Because by then Friedhelm had already become woven into his existence so completely that
being denied him felt like amputation.

Meals tasted wrong.

The estate felt wrong.

Leora's absence hurt when she left, but Friedhelm's silence had done something stranger:

it made the entire world feel emotionally unreachable.

And still Sukuna had remained.

Because he loved him.

Even then.

Especially then.

He remembered kneeling beside Friedhelm afterward months later and saying it plainly:

Even if you never speak to me again, I will remain and wait for the day you might in rapture.

Not coercion.

Not bargaining.

Truth.

Friedhelm was watching him carefully now.

Too carefully.

Sukuna suddenly realized what this question really was.

Not insecurity.

Fear.

Friedhelm was afraid this changed the nature of them.

That Wulf's existence inside the vow somehow contaminated what Sukuna felt for him now.

That Sukuna might pull away.

The realization irritated him deeply.

Sukuna turned fully toward him at last.

"You think learning another man loved you enough to bind himself to your soul permanently makes me want you less?"

Friedhelm's throat moved subtly.

“I don’t know what it makes you feel.”

“That sounds like a lie.”

Friedhelm looked away slightly at that.

Because it was.

Of course it was.

He knew Sukuna was jealous.

Leora had once called jealousy Sukuna’s most honest emotion.

And Wulf—

Gods.

Wulf.

The man between them for years.

The man Leora orbited beside Friedhelm like twin stars around a shared sun.

The man who kidnapped her after the twins were born and kept her for three months while Sukuna nearly tore the world apart trying to reach her.

The man whose love altered death on a foundational level for her.

And now apparently for Friedhelm too.

Marriage suddenly seemed embarrassingly small beside the Devouring Vow.

Sukuna exhaled sharply through his nose.

“I hate him more now,” he admitted flatly.

That startled a tiny laugh out of Friedhelm before he could stop it.

“There,” Sukuna said immediately. “That.”

Friedhelm blinked once.

“That what?”

“That sound.”

Sukuna’s voice lowered.

“You think I would willingly give that up now?”

Silence.

Then Sukuna reached over suddenly and caught Friedhelm by the wrist.

Firm.

Grounding.

“You were terrified of me once.”

Friedhelm stilled completely.

Sukuna rarely spoke directly about those months.

“They nearly killed me.”

Friedhelm’s expression cracked instantly at that.

“Sukuna—”

“No.”

His grip tightened slightly.

“You don’t get to interrupt that.”

The room felt quieter suddenly.

Even the wind outside seemed distant.

“You stopped touching me.”

His voice had gone frighteningly calm.

“You stopped looking for me.”

Another pause.

“And I stayed anyway.”

Friedhelm’s eyes were bright now.

Not crying.

Close.

Sukuna leaned closer.

“If learning you bound yourself to Wulf changes anything,” he said quietly, “it changes this.”

His fingers moved against Friedhelm’s pulse once.

“I finally understand why your grief looks immortal.”

That landed visibly.

Friedhelm looked down immediately.

Sukuna continued before he could retreat into silence.

“And I understand why losing you would destroy me permanently.”

The honesty in the room became unbearable suddenly.

Friedhelm whispered:

“You shouldn’t say things like that to me.”

“Why.”

“Because I already love you too much.”

Sukuna’s chest tightened violently at the answer.

Gods.

There it was again.

That impossible softness Friedhelm gave so quietly it almost sounded accidental.

Sukuna lifted Friedhelm's wrist slightly and pressed his mouth against the inside of it.

Slow.

Intentional.

Then rested his forehead briefly against Friedhelm's shoulder.

"No," he said quietly. "We are not stopping this."

A pause.

Then more possessively:

"You are not getting rid of me now."

For a moment Sukuna did not answer.

His forehead remained against Friedhelm's shoulder, warm breath moving softly against the fabric there. Outside, the pond rippled beneath the wind and somewhere deeper in the wing one of the foxes barked once into the night.

Friedhelm waited quietly.

Always too patient.

Sukuna's fingers moved unconsciously toward the bracelet around his wrist.

The motion happened before thought.

He noticed it immediately now.

So did Friedhelm.

The silver caught lantern light faintly where it rested against Sukuna's skin—beautiful and understated unless one knew what sat inside it.

Leora's soul.

Fragments of it.

Burned into existence to protect him.

Sukuna stared at it for several long seconds.

Then finally laughed once.

Soft.

Humorless.

“She terrifies me.”

Friedhelm did not look surprised.

Sukuna’s thumb brushed the bracelet again.

“When she told me...”

His jaw tightened slightly.

“...I thought I understood.”

But he hadn’t.

Not truly.

Not until afterward.

Not until he started replaying everything she had said to him on the veranda.

One second alone with you is worth an eternity of darkness.

I would have sacrificed one million innocent children to the forge to keep you yourself.

I would have placed myself in the fire.

Not metaphor.

Not exaggeration.

Truth.

Leora had looked at him while saying it like devotion itself was violence she had willingly sanctified.

And somehow—

somehow—

that frightened Sukuna more than any threat he had ever faced.

Because he believed her completely.

Friedhelm spoke quietly beside him.

“You keep touching it.”

Sukuna clicked his tongue softly.

“I know.”

“You do it when you’re thinking about her.”

“That’s unfortunate.”

Friedhelm’s mouth twitched faintly.

Sukuna finally lifted his head.

His eyes looked darker than before.

“When she almost died,” he said slowly, “the moment I realized what she had done...”

His throat worked once.

“...I couldn’t understand how someone could destroy themselves that willingly.”

He looked back down at the bracelet.

“And then she looked happy.”

Friedhelm went very still beside him.

Because he understood exactly what Sukuna meant.

Leora had not looked afraid when Sukuna realized.

She had looked fulfilled.

Like the worst possible thing had become sacred because he finally knew.

Sukuna's expression twisted faintly.

"She looked at me like being loved by me justified it."

Silence stretched.

Then quieter:

"She was proud of it."

The words came out almost accusing.

As if Sukuna still did not know what to do with the enormity of that devotion.

Friedhelm's gaze softened.

"She waited a very long time for someone to love her correctly."

That struck deeper than Sukuna wanted it to.

Because yes.

That was part of it too.

Leora loved like starvation finally allowed to eat.

Absolute.

Possessive.

Catastrophic.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna had always believed himself the more monstrous one between them.

Now he wasn't certain anymore.

He leaned back slightly, eyes narrowing toward the dark water outside.

"She said there's no line for her where I'm concerned."

Friedhelm smiled faintly at that.

“Yes.”

No hesitation.

No denial.

Just agreement.

Sukuna looked irritated by how unsurprised Friedhelm seemed.

“You say that like it’s normal.”

Friedhelm’s pale eyes shifted toward him calmly.

“For her?”

A tiny shrug.

“It is.”

That annoyed Sukuna even more.

“She threatened gods over me.”

“She threatened death itself over me once,” Friedhelm said mildly.

Sukuna stared at him.

Friedhelm looked thoughtful for a moment.

“She was thirteen.”

Sukuna barked out an actual laugh at that despite himself.

Of course she was.

Of course Leora Ten Brinken as a child had apparently looked at cosmic law and decided it was negotiable.

Friedhelm’s fingers brushed lightly against Sukuna’s wrist then. Against the bracelet.

“You’re upset because you understand now that her love is not survivable in ordinary ways.”

Sukuna's gaze sharpened immediately.

"That's not upsetting."

"It absolutely is."

Sukuna frowned.

Friedhelm's voice softened.

"You don't know what to do with being cherished without conditions."

The accuracy of it made Sukuna instantly hostile.

"I have conditions."

"Yes," Friedhelm agreed easily. "You do."

Then quieter:

"She doesn't care."

That silence afterward felt enormous.

Because it was true.

Leora had seen everything.

The cruelty.

The violence.

The instability.

The monstrosity.

And instead of retreating—

she had carved pieces of her own soul apart to keep the world from touching him.

Sukuna stared down at the bracelet again.

When he finally spoke, his voice had gone very quiet.

"I think if she asked me to burn the world for her now..."

A pause.

“...I would.”

Friedhelm did not recoil.

Did not look frightened.

If anything, he looked sadder.

Not because of the statement.

Because he understood it too well.

“You already were going to,” Friedhelm said softly.

Sukuna looked at him.

And realized with sudden clarity that Friedhelm was not speaking about now.

He was speaking about before.

Before love softened anything.

Before children.

Before peace.

Before this strange impossible family.

Sukuna had already been moving toward ruin willingly for her.

Leora had simply walked beside him into it smiling.

The realization settled heavily between them.

Then Friedhelm asked quietly:

“Does it make you regret wearing it?”

Sukuna looked genuinely offended.

His hand closed around the bracelet immediately.

Protectively.

“No.”

Too fast.

Too sharp.

Friedhelm's eyes softened further at that.

Sukuna exhaled slowly.

Then admitted:

"I think I'll wear it until my arm rots off."

Chapter LXXVI

Friedhelm adjusted the blanket more carefully around the sleeping children before answering.

Freyr had somehow turned in his sleep again, one tiny wolf ear flattened beneath Kohaku's cheek while Kohaku remained stubbornly attached to Freyr's sleeve even unconscious. Their tails were tangled together beneath the blankets in a knot neither child seemed capable of undoing.

Friedhelm's fingers lingered there for a moment.

Gentle.

Protective.

Then he spoke quietly without looking up.

"When I first came here... when I still wasn't certain about you..."

Sukuna's gaze shifted toward him immediately.

Friedhelm smiled faintly to himself.

"Leora used to sit right there." He nodded toward the open engawa overlooking the pond. "Usually wrapped in three blankets because she claimed Japanese winters were designed personally to offend her."

That startled the faintest smirk from Sukuna.

Friedhelm continued softly.

“She told me you were what safety actually was.”

Sukuna’s expression immediately darkened with skepticism.

“That sounds unlike her.”

“No,” Friedhelm said gently. “It sounds exactly like her.”

The lantern light flickered softly across his white hair as he leaned back slightly beside the sleeping children.

“She said you were entirely yourself.”

A pause.

“Entirely honest.”

Sukuna went still.

Friedhelm looked toward him now.

“She said you looked at sexual violence and genuinely could not understand why someone would choose it as a weapon.”

Sukuna’s mouth curled slightly in disgust.

“Because it is pathetic.”

“Yes,” Friedhelm said softly. “That was more or less her exact argument.”

Something warmer touched his expression now. Old memory softening grief for a moment.

“She said it wasn’t power.”

His eyes drifted briefly toward the pond again.

“She said weak men use violation because they cannot inspire surrender willingly.”

Sukuna was silent now.

Listening carefully.

Friedhelm's voice lowered further.

"She said you were power."

The room felt strangely intimate suddenly.

The crackle of distant incense.

Wind through willow branches.

The tiny sleeping breaths of infants nearby.

"And she said," Friedhelm continued quietly, "Sukuna is what every man in the world has ever failed to be."

Sukuna stared at him.

Actually stared.

As though he did not know what to do with hearing himself described through Leora's eyes when she was not present to soften the impact with affection and touch.

Friedhelm smiled faintly.

"She was pregnant with Kurohiko then."

That expression changed him entirely.

Softened him.

Not into fragility.

Into memory.

"She would come into this wing late at night after everyone slept."

A tiny exhale of laughter.

"Usually carrying food she claimed she wasn't hungry enough to finish herself."

Sukuna could picture it too easily.

Leora barefoot.

Wrapped in blankets.

Pregnant.

Half irritated at the cold.

Half drunk on mead.

Happy.

Friedhelm's pale eyes lowered toward the children.

"Sometimes she would cry."

That startled Sukuna visibly.

"Cry?"

"From happiness."

Friedhelm said it simply.

"As though the feeling overwhelmed her physically."

The image unsettled Sukuna in ways violence never could.

Friedhelm's voice softened further.

"She would put her hands over her stomach and say she couldn't believe she was carrying another child of yours."

Sukuna's throat tightened unexpectedly.

"She said she would lie awake listening to your heartbeat and think about how she had another piece of you growing inside her."

Silence settled heavily.

Then Friedhelm laughed softly beneath his breath.

"She drank too much mead once and spent nearly an hour insisting she didn't understand why you deemed her worthy to mother your dynasty."

Sukuna looked genuinely offended.

Friedhelm smiled wider at that.

"She kept insisting there must have been superior options somewhere."

He mimicked Leora's voice gently:

“Surely there are terrifying demonesses somewhere better suited for this than me, Friedhelm.”

Even Sukuna snorted softly at that.

Because the idea of Leora—Leora—thinking herself inadequate for anything felt absurd.

Friedhelm’s fingers moved again, carefully tucking the blanket beneath Kohaku’s tiny arm.

“Then she cried harder because Kurohiko kicked.”

Sukuna looked away sharply.

Overwhelmed suddenly in ways he deeply disliked.

The room quieted again afterward.

Outside, foxes moved somewhere beyond the pond.

Friedhelm remained focused on the children as he spoke next.

“Chōbei and Tsukihiko are exhausted.”

His hand rested briefly atop Freyr’s tiny back.

“Two newborns are apparently enough to break even them.”

A faint smile.

“I selfishly wanted to keep the boys tonight.”

Sukuna glanced toward the infants again.

Toward Kohaku sleeping beside Freyr as though they had shared a cradle their entire lives.

Then Friedhelm finally looked at him directly.

No avoidance now.

No softness hiding the seriousness beneath it.

Just honesty.

“Sukuna.”

The use of his name like that always forced attention.

Friedhelm's pale eyes held his steadily.

"You and Wulf are the only men I will ever have the capacity to love."

The words landed with terrifying weight.

Not because of comparison.

Because of finality.

Because Friedhelm almost never spoke in absolutes unless he meant them completely.

And then—

quietly:

"So please..."

For the first time that night, real vulnerability surfaced fully in his expression.

Not fear.

Not weakness.

Trust dangerous enough to resemble both.

"Don't hurt me."

The room went completely still.

Sukuna felt something inside him recoil violently at the idea.

Not because he was incapable of hurting people.

Gods knew he was not.

But because suddenly he understood this for what it truly was:

not a warning.

A request.

Friedhelm was placing his heart carefully into Sukuna's hands and asking him not to crush it accidentally.

After everything.

After Wulf.

After loss.

After fear.

After those four months of distance.

He was still choosing to trust him again.

Sukuna moved before thinking.

One hand caught Friedhelm's jaw carefully.

Not rough.

Not possessive.

Almost reverent.

"You should never say things like that to me."

Friedhelm blinked once.

"Why."

Sukuna's thumb brushed once beneath his eye.

"Because now I'll spend the rest of my existence making sure it never happens."

And for the first time all night—

Friedhelm looked relieved.

The question came so suddenly it altered the air between them.

Even the foxes outside seemed quieter.

Friedhelm looked at Sukuna immediately.

Sukuna regretted asking it almost at once.

Not because he did not want the answer.

Because he did.

Too much.

That irritation showed plainly across his face as he looked away toward the pond instead.

The lantern light reflected gold against the water. Willow branches swayed softly overhead. Somewhere deeper in the wing, wind chimes shifted once.

Friedhelm watched him carefully.

Sukuna's jaw tightened.

Then finally:

"If he came back."

A pause.

"If you could truly have him back."

His fingers curled slightly against his knee.

"Would you want that?"

There it was.

Rawer than Sukuna preferred.

Sharper.

Ugly in the way real fear often was.

Not jealousy alone.

Something worse.

Because Sukuna already knew Wulf mattered.

That was undeniable now.

The Devouring Vow.

The letter.

Freyr.

The man's presence still moved through this family like an old ghost that refused to leave.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna was suddenly forced to confront something he had never truly considered before:

What if Friedhelm had been given a choice?

Not memory.

Not grief.

Not devotion surviving death.

An actual choice.

Wulf alive.

Wulf returned.

Wulf standing here breathing.

Would Friedhelm still choose this life?

Would he still choose Sukuna?

The thought made something cold settle beneath his ribs.

Friedhelm's gaze softened almost painfully.

"Sukuna..."

"Answer the question."

Too fast.

Too sharp.

Friedhelm fell quiet.

Not avoiding.

Thinking carefully.

Which somehow made Sukuna feel worse.

Finally Friedhelm exhaled softly and leaned back slightly beside the sleeping children.

“If Wulf returned,” he said quietly, “I think part of me would stop breathing from happiness.”

Sukuna looked away immediately.

There it was.

Of course.

But Friedhelm was still speaking.

“And then,” he continued softly, “I would become furious.”

That dragged Sukuna’s eyes back toward him.

Friedhelm’s expression had gone distant now. Old grief surfacing beneath composure.

“Because he left.”

The simplicity of it hurt more than rage would have.

Friedhelm’s fingers moved absently against the blanket near Freyr.

“He chose death knowing what it would do.”

A pause.

“He chose sacrifice.”

His pale eyes lowered.

“And I have spent every day afterward surviving it.”

Sukuna remained silent.

Friedhelm smiled faintly then.

Not happy.

Knowing.

“You think love prevents anger.”

A tiny shake of his head.

“It doesn’t.”

The wind shifted colder outside.

Friedhelm finally looked directly at Sukuna again.

“If Wulf returned,” he said quietly, “I would love him.”

No hesitation.

No shame.

Truth.

Sukuna absorbed the blow without expression.

Then Friedhelm continued:

“And I would still love you.”

That struck harder somehow.

Because Sukuna believed him.

Completely.

Friedhelm was not dividing affection between them like portions.

He meant something worse.

Something larger.

That his heart had somehow made room for both.

Sukuna frowned faintly.

“That sounds exhausting.”

It startled a real laugh out of Friedhelm.

Soft and breath-warm.

“Yes,” he admitted. “It probably is.”

Sukuna stared at him for several seconds.

Then finally asked the real question beneath all the others.

“Would you leave?”

Friedhelm’s expression changed instantly.

The softness vanished into something more focused. More certain.

“No.”

Immediate.

Absolute.

Sukuna stilled.

Friedhelm leaned slightly closer.

“I built this life too.”

His eyes moved briefly toward the sleeping children.

Toward the wing.

The pond.

The estate beyond it.

“You think you’re the only one who became attached?”

Sukuna did not answer.

Because yes.

Perhaps part of him had believed that.

Friedhelm’s voice lowered.

“You are part of my home now.”

That word again.

Home.

Sukuna hated how much it affected him.

Friedhelm continued gently:

“Wulf belongs to my soul.”

A pause.

“And you belong to my life.”

That should not have comforted Sukuna as much as it did.

But it did.

Deeply.

Because Friedhelm was not speaking in lesser terms.

He was speaking in different ones.

Wulf was grief.

Memory.

Ancient devotion.

But Sukuna—

Sukuna was here.

Breathing beside him.

Touching him.

Building a future with him.

The distinction mattered.

Friedhelm reached out then and touched Sukuna’s wrist lightly.

Near the bracelet.

“And if I’m honest,” he admitted quietly, “I think Wulf would like you.”

Sukuna looked horrified.

Friedhelm laughed softly again.

“No,” Sukuna said immediately. “Don’t say things like that.”

“He would.”

“He kidnapped Leora.”

“And she still speaks about him like weather she survived fondly.”

“That is because she’s insane.”

“Yes,” Friedhelm agreed easily. “But she’s usually correct about people.”

Sukuna clicked his tongue in annoyance.

Friedhelm’s smile lingered.

Then softer:

“You don’t have to compete with a dead man.”

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed immediately.

“I would win.”

That made Friedhelm laugh hard enough he had to lower his voice to avoid waking the babies.

And Sukuna—

despite everything—

felt strangely better hearing it.

Chapter LXXVII

Friedhelm reached toward him slowly.

Not hesitant.

Careful.

His fingers brushed along Sukuna's cheek, thumb resting near the sharp line of his jaw. The touch alone quieted something in the room.

Outside, the pond reflected fractured lanternlight through the open screens. Wind moved softly through the willow branches. Somewhere deeper in the wing, a fox barked once before settling again.

The children slept beside them completely unaware that the foundations of entire lives were being spoken aloud nearby.

Friedhelm looked directly into Sukuna's eyes and said it plainly.

"Leora loved Wulf."

No avoidance.
No softening.

"I loved Wulf."

His hand remained warm against Sukuna's face.

"And Wulf loved us both."

Sukuna did not move.

Friedhelm's pale gaze drifted briefly toward the sleeping children before returning.

"Leora survived me taking her away from him after he won the right to marry her."

The memory moved visibly through him.

Old grief.
Old guilt.
Old understanding.

"Wulf made the Devouring Vow with me because he wanted me to understand what I was to him."

A faint exhale.

"I broke his heart."

That landed heavily.

Not dramatically.

Quietly.

Like an old fracture still embedded beneath the skin.

“He didn’t understand at first,” Friedhelm continued softly. “And then when he finally did...”

A sad smile touched his mouth.

“He still believed Leora needed to remain inside the system to survive.”

Sukuna frowned slightly.

Friedhelm’s expression darkened with memory.

“He kidnapped her to protect her.”

That old instinctive hostility surged immediately through Sukuna’s body despite himself.

Friedhelm noticed.

“Listen to me.”

The words were gentle.

Firm.

“If he had not taken her away then...”

He paused.

And Sukuna understood before the sentence finished.

The children.

Kaguya.

Exposure.

The tribes.

Death.

Friedhelm's eyes lowered briefly.

"He would have killed the children himself before allowing them to be taken by the tribes."

Silence.

Heavy.

Terrible.

"And if he couldn't do it," Friedhelm whispered, "he would have exposed Kaguya's existence and forced the tribes to do it for him."

Sukuna felt sickened suddenly by how believable that was.

Not cruelty.

Conviction.

The kind born from systems so monstrous they convinced people death could become mercy.

Friedhelm watched him carefully.

Then his expression sharpened.

More serious now.

"The way he treated you," he said quietly, "the way he fought you—"

His thumb moved once against Sukuna's cheek.

"—that was respect."

Sukuna's eyes narrowed slightly.

Friedhelm continued anyway.

"You had never met a real foe before Wulf."

The statement should have sounded insulting.

Instead it sounded factual.

Sukuna remembered the fight instantly.

Snow.

Blood.

The pressure of someone who refused to break.

Someone who moved like destruction itself had learned discipline.

Friedhelm's gaze became distant with memory.

"I watched the two of you."

A pause.

"Wulf had the advantage."

That startled actual irritation into Sukuna's expression.

Friedhelm smiled faintly.

"You know he did."

Annoyingly—

yes.

Part of Sukuna had known it too.

Friedhelm continued softly:

"He was built similarly to you."

The words carried strange weight.

"Not physically."

His fingers traced lightly downward along Sukuna's jaw.

"Fundamentally."

That stilled Sukuna completely.

"You and Wulf are not easily distinguished from one another in certain ways."

The realization settled unpleasantly deep.

Friedhelm watched it happen.

“And that,” he said quietly, “is why this works.”

Sukuna frowned faintly.

Friedhelm’s eyes softened.

“Because you love Leora the way she deserves to be loved.”

No hesitation.

No uncertainty.

Absolute certainty.

Then quieter:

“And now you love me in a way meant specifically for me.”

Sukuna’s throat tightened.

Friedhelm’s hand slipped from his face only so he could rest it over Sukuna’s wrist instead.

Near the bracelet.

“We had to let Wulf go.”

The sentence nearly disappeared into the sound of the wind outside.

“But eventually...”

A tiny sad smile.

“We found our new axis in you.”

Sukuna stared at him.

That word again.

Axis.

Not replacement.

Not substitute.

The point around which their lives now stabilized.

Friedhelm leaned back slightly afterward, glancing once more toward the sleeping infants tangled together beneath blankets.

Then he said quietly:

“This is why, when you told me you wanted me to find a permanent partner...”

He looked back toward Sukuna.

“I told Leora to stop looking.”

Sukuna blinked once.

Actually surprised.

Friedhelm’s expression remained calm.

Certain.

“It’s Wulf or you for me.”

The honesty of it hit like a blade straight through the center of Sukuna’s chest.

No performance.

No dramatics.

Just truth.

“I don’t need anyone else.”

Silence followed.

Long.

Sukuna looked away first.

Toward the pond.

Toward the foxes moving beneath moonlight.

Toward the impossible strange life he somehow occupied now.

Children sleeping nearby.

Leora somewhere else in the estate probably half awake waiting for him.

Friedhelm beside him speaking about love like it was both tragedy and inevitability.

Finally Sukuna exhaled slowly.

“You make it sound very simple.”

Friedhelm’s smile returned.

Soft.

Almost unbearably fond.

“No,” he said quietly.

“We make it work because none of us were built for simple things.”

Friedhelm reached for him first this time.

Not delicately.

Needfully.

His hands slid beneath Sukuna’s outer robe and pulled him closer until Sukuna finally gave in to the pressure and let himself be drawn down against him.

The movement shifted them both against the cushions near the open pond screens. Friedhelm leaned back instinctively beneath Sukuna’s weight, white hair loosening slightly from where it had been styled. In the lanternlight it looked almost unreal against the red-painted wood and soft blue fabrics surrounding them.

Sukuna’s hands settled hard against Friedhelm’s hips automatically.

Grounding him.

Reorienting him.

Friedhelm sighed at the contact immediately.

Happy.

That sound alone nearly destroyed Sukuna’s restraint.

He had learned quickly that Friedhelm responded differently than Leora did. Leora surged toward intensity like fire fed air. Friedhelm—

Friedhelm drifted.

Not intentionally.

His mind simply knew too many ways to leave himself behind when emotion became too large.

So Sukuna had learned roughness carefully.

Not cruelty.

Weight.

Pressure.

Hands that kept him here.

Hands impossible to ignore.

Friedhelm shifted again beneath him and a soft involuntary sound escaped his throat.

Sukuna felt it like a blade sliding directly under his ribs.

His grip tightened instantly.

Dangerously.

Friedhelm noticed.

Of course he did.

A faint smile touched his mouth just before he leaned upward and kissed him.

Slow at first.

Then deeper.

Sukuna could already feel it happening beneath the surface—the subtle loosening in Friedhelm’s body that meant he was beginning to drift too far inward again.

Immediately Sukuna’s hand moved.

Firm against the side of Friedhelm’s throat.

He pushed him gently backward and away from his mouth.

Friedhelm inhaled sharply at the sudden control.

Sukuna stared down at him.

Years ago that expression might have frightened Friedhelm.

Now it made him visibly shiver instead.

Sukuna watched every reaction carefully.

Then quietly asked:

“Will you always be honest with me?”

The question landed harder than any touch had.

Friedhelm’s face changed instantly.

Not fear.

Something heartbreakingly hopeful.

His eyes brightened so suddenly Sukuna thought for one terrible second he might actually cry.

“That,” Friedhelm whispered, voice uneven, “is all I’ve ever wanted with someone.”

His fingers curled lightly against Sukuna’s sleeve.

“I just want to be able to tell the truth without meeting a closed fist.”

Sukuna felt something vicious twist inside his chest.

Because now he knew.

Now every strange habit had context.

Every flinch hidden quickly.

Every careful tone adjustment.

Every instinct to soothe before speaking honestly.

The Lieder demonstration had ruined ignorance forever.

After seeing what Friedrichshafen had done to Friedhelm—to both of them—

entire decades of behavior had rearranged themselves into horrifying clarity.

Sukuna lowered his gaze briefly.

Then Friedhelm's hands moved again.

Curious.

Gentle.

They slid downward across Sukuna's abdomen, fingers brushing over the fabric there before hooking lightly against the tie at his waistband.

Sukuna caught his wrist immediately.

Friedhelm made the softest disappointed sound imaginable.

Sukuna nearly lost his mind over it.

Instead of releasing him, he bent his head and pressed slow kisses against Friedhelm's neck and jaw.

Immediate reaction.

Friedhelm's breath caught sharply.

His head tilted back before he could stop himself.

Sukuna smirked directly against his throat.

"There," he murmured quietly. "Stay with me."

Friedhelm laughed softly under the words, visibly affected by both the command and the affection woven together inside it.

Sukuna brushed another kiss beneath his jaw before asking:

"Would you like to move somewhere more comfortable?"

Friedhelm opened his eyes slowly.

There was no hesitation in his answer.

“No.”

Soft.

Certain.

“I’m exactly where I want to be.”

Something in Sukuna’s expression softened at that.

Not visibly to most people.

But Friedhelm saw it.

Always.

Outside, beyond the open screens, the pond reflected fractured moonlight through the willow branches.

Two foxes had curled together near the water’s edge sometime during the conversation. Tiny fox pups slept tangled against their sides, soft tails twitching occasionally in dreams.

And for a little while longer—

the world remained quiet.

Chapter LXXVIII

Every time Sukuna tried to leave, Friedhelm somehow prevented it.

At first it seemed accidental.

A hand catching his sleeve.

A knee sliding across his lap.

A soft request to stay another minute while he checked on the babies.

Then Sukuna realized, much too late, that this was war.

Not physical combat.

Proximity warfare.

And somehow—

the Fox King was winning.

Friedhelm moved with deceptive softness, all quiet touches and absent affection, but every motion guided Sukuna exactly where he wanted him. If Sukuna shifted away, Friedhelm shifted closer. If Sukuna stood, Friedhelm caught his wrist and pulled him back down beside him with sleepy insistence.

Sometimes he simply climbed onto him.

Completely shameless.

Sukuna had discovered that Friedhelm weaponized affection with terrifying precision.

His kisses tasted like sweet wine and warm breath.

His hands were somehow too gentle and too rough simultaneously, grounding Sukuna without ever making it obvious he was doing so.

And worst of all—

Sukuna liked it.

By dawn the sheets had become tangled beyond saving.

Sukuna lay stretched across the bedding on his stomach, one arm beneath his head, watching through half-lidded eyes as Friedhelm rose again to check on the children.

Freyr had begun making tiny restless noises in his crib.

Immediately Friedhelm went.

Of course he did.

His white hair had become messy and soft around his shoulders and neck. In the pale blue-grey light before sunrise, his skin almost seemed luminous against the warm red cypress wood surrounding the room.

He leaned over the crib and lifted Freyr carefully.

The baby quieted almost instantly.

Sukuna watched Friedhelm kiss one tiny wolf ear.

Then the other.

Soft little murmurs in a language Sukuna didn't recognize drifted through the room afterward.

And suddenly—

the realization hit him fully.

Friedhelm had never become a father himself.

Not truly.

Not biologically.

But he had raised every one of Sukuna's children anyway.

Kurohiko.

Kaguya.

Mizuki.

Higan.

Tsukihiko.

For years Friedhelm had been their comfort.

Their emotional refuge.

Their softness.

Their patience.

The one they climbed into bed with after nightmares.

The one who taught them gentleness when Sukuna himself did not know how to.

And he had done it while carrying grief large enough to drown entire kingdoms.

Sukuna stared openly at him.

Actually stared.

Friedhelm looked over at him then, smiling faintly when he noticed.

He looked impossibly beautiful standing there shirtless in the early dawn light with Freyr against his chest.

Carefree for once.

Not frightened.

Not guarded.

Not surviving.

Just alive.

And Sukuna found himself wondering something he genuinely could not understand:

How had this man survived everything done to him and still remained this sweet?

How had the world failed to rot him completely?

Friedhelm settled Freyr back into the crib carefully, adjusting the blankets and brushing tiny fingers away from the child's face before finally returning to the bed.

He crawled back toward Sukuna slowly.

Deliberately.

Then climbed onto his back like a lazy fox claiming warmth.

A trail of kisses followed across Sukuna's shoulder.

His spine.

The edge of one tattooed shoulder blade.

Sukuna closed his eyes.

The feeling of Friedhelm there—
warm and living and safe—
hurt almost unbearably.

Finally he said quietly:

"I'll do my best to make you happy."

Friedhelm hummed softly against his skin.

Then lightly nipped one shoulder blade.

"You already succeed."

Sukuna's chest tightened painfully.

Because Friedhelm meant it.

That was the problem.

He meant it completely.

But Sukuna—

Sukuna still looked at everything Friedhelm had survived and wondered if happiness offered by someone like him could ever truly be enough.

Chapter LXXIV

Sukuna returned to Leora later than expected.

Not dramatically. Not hurried. Just... later.

And the moment he stepped back into their shared space, he immediately felt it.

The atmosphere was wrong.

Leora was sitting near the low table by the window, hair loose and still slightly damp from washing. Morning light spilled across her shoulders, softening everything except her expression.

Which was pointedly displeased.

She didn't look at him at first.

That was the first sign something was truly off.

Sukuna paused.

Leora usually greeted him in some form—touch, eye contact, a comment sharp or affectionate depending on her mood.

Today she did neither.

She simply shifted her gaze slightly away, as if he were part of the furniture she had decided to ignore.

Sukuna blinked once.

Then slowly stepped further inside.

“Leora.”

No response.

Not even acknowledgment.

That, more than anything, caught his attention properly.

He watched her carefully now. The subtle tension in her shoulders. The way her fingers tightened once against her sleeve before she deliberately relaxed them again, as if refusing to give him the satisfaction of noticing.

She was... sulking.

Properly.

Sukuna stood there for a moment longer, processing this with the same intensity he would give a battlefield development.

Leora Ten Brinken was actively refusing to look at him.

Not out of fear.

Not out of anger in the usual sense.

Out of petulant offense.

He moved closer.

Leora immediately turned her head further away.

Deliberately.

Exaggeratedly.

Her chin lifted slightly as if she were committing to the decision with full dignity.

Sukuna stopped walking.

“...Are you ignoring me?”

Silence.

Then a small, almost imperceptible shift of her posture that made it very clear she had heard him and chosen to continue ignoring him anyway.

Sukuna's expression changed.

Not into irritation.

Into something far more dangerous for everyone involved:

interest.

He leaned slightly to the side to try and catch her face.

Leora turned further away again.

Perfectly timed.

Absolutely committed.

It was almost impressive.

Sukuna stared at her for a long moment.

Then slowly exhaled through his nose.

"This is new."

That got a reaction.

A tiny tightening of her jaw.

Still no eye contact.

But now there was intent behind the silence.

Sukuna stepped closer again, lowering his voice slightly.

"You're upset."

Leora made a small sound that was not quite agreement and not quite denial.

Then—finally—she shifted just enough to make it obvious she was repositioning herself away from him again.

As if physically refusing proximity was part of the point.

Sukuna's gaze followed her movement.

He was... genuinely intrigued now.

Leora rarely withheld attention like this. If she was angry, she expressed it directly. If she was amused, it was obvious. If she was affectionate, it was overwhelming.

This—this contained restraint layered over stubbornness—was unfamiliar.

And strangely deliberate.

"Look at me," he said calmly.

Leora did not.

Instead, she turned her entire upper body slightly away from him, reinforcing the pout like it was a tactical decision.

Sukuna stared.

Then, against his better judgment—

he felt the corner of his mouth twitch.

"...You're sulking."

Leora's shoulders lifted faintly in what could only be described as offended confirmation.

Still not looking at him.

Still refusing.

Sukuna tilted his head slowly.

For a moment, he simply observed her.

Then he stepped closer again, quieter now.

"You're doing this because I didn't return last night."

A pause.

Leora went very still.

That was answer enough.

Sukuna exhaled softly, eyes narrowing slightly—not in anger, but in realization.

She was genuinely annoyed.

Not performative.

Not strategic.

Personal.

That alone made it more interesting.

He leaned in slightly, trying again to catch her gaze.

Leora immediately turned her face away in the most dramatic possible refusal.

Sukuna stopped.

Stared.

Then—

very quietly—

he laughed under his breath.

That made her freeze.

Just for a second.

Sukuna noticed.

Of course he did.

“You’re pouting,” he repeated, softer this time.

Leora gave a small, indignant shift of her shoulders.

Still not looking at him.

But now she was very clearly listening.

Sukuna's eyes lingered on her for a moment longer.

Then, with a patience that didn't quite match his usual nature, he stepped closer and lowered his voice.

"...Come here."

Leora did not move.

But the tension in her posture changed.

Because now she was deciding whether to continue the act.

And Sukuna—

Sukuna was watching her decide.

Leora stood.

The decision was immediate and deliberate.

Sukuna watched it happen with quiet attention as she turned away from him and walked toward the door without another word.

That, more than anything, confirmed she was serious.

He considered letting her go.

Just long enough to see if she actually would.

Then discarded the thought immediately.

He didn't want her to leave.

So he moved.

He stepped into her path before she reached the door.

Leora didn't stop.

She simply shifted her weight and pushed him.

Not hard enough to hurt.

Hard enough to be insulting.

Sukuna blinked once.

Then laughed.

Leora tried to slip past him while he was reacting, but he adjusted instantly, blocking her again. She pushed his shoulder this time, sharper, more deliberate, and for a moment Sukuna let her drive him back until his spine met the door behind him.

Leora reached for the handle.

Sukuna caught her wrist.

She twisted out.

Too fast.

Too practiced.

He grabbed for her again and found only empty air and a faint brush of her sleeve as she ducked under his arm.

Leora managed to pull the door open.

Just enough.

Cold air from the hall slipped in.

Sukuna's expression shifted.

Then he stepped forward, caught her from behind, and pulled her back into the room with controlled strength.

Leora immediately twisted, trying to turn it into a reversal.

He laughed again—low, pleased—and lifted her cleanly off her feet.

She made a sharp sound of frustration and immediately started hitting his back.

Not panicked.

Not afraid.

Annoyed.

Sukuna carried her like that for exactly three steps before she managed to hook her arm around his shoulder and try to shift her weight, forcing him to adjust his grip or lose control of her entirely.

It was—

honestly—

fun.

He tightened his hold at her thighs and hip, laughing under his breath as she kept struggling.

“You’re persistent,” he said mildly.

Leora responded by attempting to elbow him.

He pivoted, turned, and in one smooth motion dropped her onto the bed.

Or tried to.

Because she twisted mid-air, caught his arm, and dragged him down with her enough that they both hit the mattress in a tangled collision instead of a clean pin.

Sukuna paused.

Then his eyes lit up.

“Oh,” he said softly.

Leora immediately tried to roll him off.

He let her get halfway.

Then reversed it.

She slipped out.

He caught her ankle.

She used it to pivot.

He shifted.

She struck a pressure point at his wrist.

He laughed outright.

This was no longer an argument.

It was a war of proximity.

And Sukuna realized, with growing satisfaction, that Leora fought like someone who knew exactly how to make being caught difficult.

Every hold he attempted met resistance that was intelligent, precise, and just slightly personal.

Every escape she made was just insulting enough to be intentional.

At one point she bit his hand.

Not hard enough to break skin.

Hard enough to make her point.

Sukuna actually laughed at that.

She glared at him immediately.

Then pushed him back again when he leaned in too close.

“No,” she said firmly.

Sukuna paused mid-motion.

“...No?”

Leora’s eyes narrowed.

“No kiss.”

That made him stop properly.

He blinked.

Then tilted his head slightly.

“And why not?”

Leora hesitated for half a second.

Then:

“You still smell like Friedhelm.”

Silence.

Sukuna stared at her.

Then slowly said, almost amused:

“That has never bothered you before.”

A beat.

“...Not even that one time—”

Leora’s entire body went still.

Then she shot forward and covered his mouth with her hand.

Her face was instantly red.

Completely, unmistakably red.

Sukuna stopped talking.

And for a moment—

just a moment—

he looked at her hand over his mouth.

Then up at her eyes.

And his expression changed.

Not softer.

Not calmer.

Just brighter.

Dangerously entertained.

“Oh,” he murmured against her palm.

His eyes lit up fully now.

Because whatever this was—

this was no longer just sulking.

This was personal.

Sukuna shifted his weight and, with a controlled motion that left no room for her to slip away, pinned her properly.

One wrist locked above her head.

His knee settled against her hip—firm, deliberate, grounding her in place.

Leora reacted immediately.

Not in panic.

In instinct.

She strained once, testing him, and nearly broke the hold before Sukuna adjusted his weight with an ease that made it clear he was only allowing what he chose to allow.

His eyes tracked her movement like he was enjoying every second of it.

Then he leaned down.

Close enough that his voice didn't need to carry.

Close enough that she had to feel it.

“You didn’t mind sharing me with Friedhelm two weeks ago,” he said quietly, almost conversationally. “When you both had our way with me. I walked into my chambers and you and he took turns moving against me, sometimes separately and sometimes together. It felt rehearsed.”

Leora made a sharp, mortified sound and twisted hard enough that her shoulder almost slipped free before he tightened his hold again.

Sukuna didn’t even sound bothered.

He just leaned in further, breath brushing near her ear, steady and infuriatingly calm.

“You two seemed completely at ease.”

Leora froze for half a second.

Then made a small, distressed noise that was half embarrassment, half protest, and tried again to push out of his grip.

Sukuna didn’t let her.

Not even a little.

He held her exactly where she was.

And then—

his voice changed.

“Why are you really upset?”

That stopped her.

Not his strength.

Not the pin.

That question.

The fight drained out of her body in stages. First her shoulders loosened. Then her breath evened. Then she stopped struggling entirely, as if the effort had suddenly become pointless.

A long exhale left her.

“...I wanted you,” she said finally.

Quiet.

Honest.

“I waited all night.”

Sukuna didn’t move.

Leora’s gaze flicked away for a moment, then back again like she refused to let herself retreat from the admission.

“I was sitting here,” she continued, voice tightening slightly, “burning for you while you were keeping the fire stoked at Friedhelm’s.”

That landed.

Sukuna’s eyes narrowed just slightly, not in offense—more like he was absorbing the shape of it.

Then, softer:

“Why didn’t you come get me?”

Leora opened her mouth.

Stopped.

For a second, something flickered behind her expression—an answer she started to give, one she abandoned halfway.

Then she exhaled again, more controlled this time.

She didn’t finish the sentence.

Sukuna didn’t press.

Instead, something in him shifted—subtle, unreadable, but present.

Not disagreement.

Not dismissal.

A quiet acceptance of the logic she didn't even fully speak.

Leora's eyes sharpened at that silence.

As if she disliked it more than argument.

She reached up suddenly and grabbed his jaw, forcing his attention fully back to her.

"When I want you," she said, firm now, "I want you."

A beat.

Then, sharper:

"You should come crawling."

Sukuna stared at her for a moment.

Then exhaled through his nose.

"...Do you forget who you're speaking to?"

His voice was calm again, but there was something threaded through it now—something amused, something dangerous.

"The King of Curses doesn't crawl."

Leora didn't flinch.

Instead, she looked at him like she was considering something deeply unfair.

Then she smiled.

Wicked.

Soft around the edges, sharp underneath.

"Can you honestly say," she asked, "you'd deny me anything if it pleased me?"

Silence.

Not immediate.

Not instinctive.

A pause where Sukuna actually considered it.

And that was the answer.

He couldn't.

Not fully.

Leora saw it in his face before he said anything.

And that was enough.

She lifted her hand again, not to strike, not to push—

but to cup his face.

Gently this time.

Commanding in a completely different way.

"I expect you," she said, quieter now, "to stay here all day."

Sukuna blinked once.

Leora's thumb brushed his jaw.

"And even if the estate catches on fire," she continued, utterly serious, "you won't leave without my permission."

That should have sounded absurd.

It didn't.

Sukuna stared at her.

Something in his expression tightened for a fraction of a second—like a reaction he didn't immediately decide what to do with.

Then—

a scoff.

An eye roll.

Carefully performed indifference.

“...Fine.”

The word landed between them like it had weight.

Leora watched him for a second longer, as if checking whether he would take it back.

He didn't.

And Sukuna, still holding her pinned, realized something inconvenient.

He didn't like how much he liked agreeing.